Master's Thesis in Linguistics: Empirical and Theoretical Foundations

Department Linguistik
Universität Potsdam

Negation Without Concord: High Negation in Czech Polar Questions

Michaela Chodounská

First Supervisor: Dr. Mariia Privizentseva
Second Supervisor: Prof. Dr. Martin Salzmann

July 6, 2026

Acknowledgements

I would sincerely like to thank both Masha Privizentseva and Martin Salzmann for their support with this rollercoaster of a thesis. My time spent at the University of Potsdam will always remain one of the most cherished, insightful times of my life. Little did I know that coming to this faculty would spark an interest in pursuing this further, and who knows where else.

My gratitude also goes to all the children of the Advanced Kindergarten™. A home will always be a place where your loved ones are, and for me, Berlin will be that place, because it is where I will get to see the family I made here again.

To největší díky pak patří hlavně Radimovi. Nikdy by mě nenapadlo, že na to nejcennější, co kdy v životě budu mít, narazím zrovna během stěhování do cizí země. A že všechno, co se mi kdy zdálo jako nemožné, je najednou o tolik snazší. Jenom díky tomu, že tě mám.

Statement

I hereby declare that this thesis was carried out wholly in candidature for a degree at the University of Potsdam, and that it is my own work, written independently, with no sources or aids other than those cited. No part of this thesis has previously been submitted for a degree or any other qualification at this or any other university. Where I have cited the published work of others, this has been clearly attributed and referenced in accordance with standard academic practice.

July 6, 2026 in Berlin Michaela Chodounská

Abstract

This thesis explores Czech polar questions and their inability to license negative concord items (NCIs) when negated. Following Zeijlstra (2004, 2022), we take negative concord to be an instance of syntactic agreement where all negative elements agree with a covert negative operator. The syntactic view of the matter is further suggested by data from long-distance scrambling and scrambling from an embedded predicate within the main clause. However, data also further suggest that movement is not at play in interrogative polar questions and the lack of NC. For this reason, we turn to how negation behaves broadly in polar questions and conclude that its nature may be expletive, i.e. not bringing any negative force, which is also supported cross-linguistically, notably by the Modern Greek *min/dhen* split Tsiakmakis (2025). Based on these observations, we analyze polar questions as having two possible merge sites of negation. Crucially, in interrogative questions, this merge site is proposed above the propositional TP layer in the left periphery, where it cannot enter into the agreement relation with the negative operator and yields an epistemic interpretation which surfaces as speaker bias. Unlike declarative and embedded polar questions, which retain a low negation and license NCIs normally, interrogative questions thus lack the low negation required for negative concord.

Keywords: polar questions; Czech; negation; expletive negation; negative concord

Abstract (DE)

Diese Arbeit untersucht die Unfähigkeit negierter tschechischer Polfragen, Negative Concord Elemente (NCIs) zu lizenzieren. Im Anschluss an Zeijlstra (2004, 2022) fassen wir Negative Concord als eine Instanz syntaktischer Kongruenz auf, bei der alle negativen Elemente mit einem verdeckten Negationsoperator kongruieren. Diese syntaktische Sichtweise wird durch Daten aus dem Langdistanz-Scrambling sowie dem Scrambling aus einem eingebetteten Prädikat innerhalb des Matrixsatzes zusätzlich gestützt. Die Daten legen jedoch ebenfalls nahe, dass Bewegung in interrogativen Polfragen und beim Ausbleiben von NC nicht beteiligt ist. Aus diesem Grund wenden wir uns der Frage zu, wie sich Negation in Polfragen allgemein verhält, und gelangen zu dem Schluss, dass ihre Natur expletiv sein könnte, d.h. dass sie keine negative Kraft beisteuert, was auch sprachübergreifend gestützt wird, insbesondere durch die Unterscheidung zwischen min und dhen im Neugriechischen. Auf der Grundlage dieser Beobachtungen analysieren wir Polfragen als Strukturen mit zwei möglichen Merge-Positionen der Negation. Entscheidend ist, dass diese Merge-Position in interrogativen Fragen oberhalb der propositionalen TP-Ebene in der linken Satzperipherie angesetzt wird, wo sie nicht in die Kongruenzbeziehung mit dem Negationsoperator eintreten kann und eine epistemische Interpretation ergibt, die sich als Sprecher-Bias äußert. Anders als deklarative und eingebettete Polfragen, die eine tiefe Negation beibehalten und NCIs normal lizenzieren, fehlt interrogativen Fragen somit die für Negative Concord erforderliche tiefe Negation.

Schlüsselwörter: Polfragen; Tschechisch; Negation; expletive Negation; Negative Concord

Contents

List of Figures

List of Tables

1 Introduction 1
2 Negation and Negative Concord 3
2.1 Strict and Non-Strict Negative Concord 4
2.2 Zeijlstra's Analysis of Negative Concord 6
2.3 Drawing the Line Between NCIs and NPIs 10
2.3.1 Downward Entailment 12
2.3.2 Likelihood Scenarios 14
2.3.3 Fragment Answers 15
2.3.4 Neg-raising constructions 16
2.3.5 Long-Distance Scrambling 18
2.3.6 Embedded Predicate Extraction 20
2.4 Interim Summary 22
3 Polar Questions 23
3.1 The Data 23
3.2 Is It Just Movement? 27
3.3 It Is the Utterance Type 30
3.3.1 Non-veridical and Non-negative 31
3.3.2 The Negative in Negation 34
3.3.3 Evaluative Negation 38
3.4 The Left Periphery 41
3.4.1 Krifka's Proposal for Assertions 41

3.4.2 Questions and Beyond 46
3.5 Interim Summary 50
4 Analysis 51
4.1 Interrogative Polar Questions 53
4.2 Declarative Polar Questions 56
4.3 Embedded Polar Questions 58
5 Conclusion 60

References **63**

List of Figures

1 Schematic tree diagrams for Italian NC as syntactic agreement. . . 7
2 Schematic tree diagrams for Czech NC as syntactic agreement. . . 8
3 Schematic tree diagram for interrogative polar questions in Czech. 55
4 Schematic tree diagram for declarative polar questions in Czech. . 57
5 Schematic tree diagram for embedded polar questions in Czech. . 59

List of Tables

1 Summary of the licensing conditions for NPIs and NCIs in Czech. . 22
2 Summary of the diagnostics of expletive negation applied to Czech polar questions. 37

1 Introduction

As a Strict Negative Concord language, Czech can display multiple negative elements within a single sentence yet still yield only one semantic negation. Thus, as can be seen in an illustrative Example (1), a negative verbal marker *ne-* together with negative concord items (NCIs, also n-words, neg-words, or *ni*-words) such as *nikdo* 'nobody' make for a reading which corresponds to a simple negation, i.e., a truth-value reversal, that holds no matter the word order of the elements in the clause.

(1) **Nikdo** *(**ne**-)viděl **nikoho** z nich.
nobody.NCI *(NEG-)saw nobody.NCI of them
'Nobody saw any of them.'

In contrast to many analyses of Negative Concord and NCIs which heavily rely on semantics (Zanuttini, 1991, 1997; Laka, 1990; Giannakidou, 1998, 2000, i.a.), Zeijlstra (2004, 2022) takes it to be a purely syntactic phenomenon. Specifically for Strict Negative Concord languages, he assumes a phonologically empty (covert) Operator, $Op_{\neg}$, which enters a feature checking mechanism with all the negative elements present, see Example (2).

This operator bears an interpretable negation feature [iNeg] and all the other elements bear complementary [uNeg] features which are checked off in the derivation to yield a negative reading. In this way, Zeijlstra aims to explain the relatively free word order of NCIs along with the sensitivity of NCI licensing towards syntactic constraints. The only thing that is required is for the $Op_{\neg}$ to be within the same clause as all other elements bearing [uNeg].

(2) [[$Op_{\neg[\text{iNeg}]}$ [TP Nikdo$_{[\text{uNeg}]}$ [NegP ne$_{[\text{uNeg}]}$ [*v*P viděl nikoho$_{[\text{uNeg}]}$ z nich]]]]]
(Zeijlstra, 2022)

However, Czech polar questions, which will be under discussion in this thesis, seem to be an apparent counterexample to this approach and require a more comprehensive analysis. As Example (3-a) shows, no matter the negative agreement marker *ne-* on the preposed verb in an interrogative question, the NCI *nikoho* 'nobody' cannot be licensed and the question becomes completely unacceptable. On the other hand, positive polarity items (PPIs), i.e., elements anti-licensed by negation, can be used without any difficulties, see (3-b).

(3) INTERROGATIVE QUESTIONS

a. ***Ne**-viděl Marek **nikoho** z nich?
NEG-saw Marek nobody.NCI of them

int. 'Is it the case that Marek saw none of them?'

b. **Ne**-viděl Marek někoho z nich?
NEG-saw Marek somebody.PPI of them
'Didn't Marek see one of them?'

On the other hand, when a polar question is non-canonical and exhibits a declarative word order, both NCIs and PPIs are possible (although for PPIs, with a slightly degraded acceptability), as in (4).[1] Thus, unlike interrogative questions, declarative questions seem to resemble polarity item licensing seen in declarative clauses.

(4) DECLARATIVE QUESTIONS

a. Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho** z nich?
Marek NEG-saw nobody.NCI of them
'Marek didn't see any of them?'

b. ?Marek **ne**-viděl někoho z nich?
Marek NEG-saw somebody.PPI of them
'Marek didn't see some of them?'

Furthermore, this pattern can also be seen in embedded polar interrogative clauses such as those in Example (5). Interestingly enough, embedded questions seem to be insensitive to the position of the verb; if the polar interrogative complementizer *jestli* 'whether' stays in C, the verb can appear anywhere below yet still license both NCIs and PPIs without any differences in acceptability.

(5) EMBEDDED QUESTIONS

a. Ptal se, jestli (ne-viděl) Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho** z
he.asked REFL COMPL (NEG-saw) Marek NEG-saw nobody.NCI of
nich (ne-viděl).
them (NEG-saw)
'He asked whether Marek didn't see any of them.'

b. Ptal se, jestli (ne-viděl) Marek **ne**-viděl někoho z
he.asked REFL COMPL (NEG-saw) Marek NEG-saw somebody.PPI of
nich (ne-viděl).
them (NEG-saw)
'He asked whether Marek didn't see some of them.'

Further on, we argue in support of Zeijlstra (2022) and his analysis of Negative Concord as syntactic agreement. However, based on the observations from Czech

[1] Judgements presented for polar questions are based on experimental data from Staňková (2023). In her experiments, Staňková notes that in declarative questions, PPIs such as *někdo* 'somebody' were judged to be less acceptable than NCIs, yet still perceived as felicitous.

polar questions, Zeijlstra's approach must be reconsidered as for the conditions where the $Op_{\neg}$ emerges, especially with regard to the utterance type encoded in the left periphery (Rizzi, 1997; Krifka, 2024, i.a.).

The thesis is organized as follows. In Section 2, we introduce the core mechanisms of Negative Concord and specifically, Strict Negative Concord which Czech is considered to be an instance of. Then, we present the analysis of Negative Concord proposed by Zeijlstra and provide some additional supporting arguments for treating NC as a syntactic phenomenon. This will then serve us as the starting point for understanding Czech polar questions described in Section 3 and how utterance type plays a significant role in our refinement of Zeijlstra's initial proposal. Taking into account the presented argument, we introduce an analysis of Czech polar questions in Section 4 and discuss some of the questions that are raised. Section 5 concludes the thesis.

2 Negation and Negative Concord

What is crucial for understanding the data just discussed is the notion of *Negative Concord* (NC) and, correspondingly, the nature of negation in Negative Concord languages. To fully introduce this concept, we must fist understand the central difference in the dichotomy of languages when it comes to expressing negation. On the other side of the spectrum to NC, there stand Double Negation (DN) languages.

In NC languages, when two and possibly more negative elements occur in a sentence, they together yield a single negative reading. From a compositional perspective, it would be expected that the presence of multiple negative elements neutralizes negation. In other words, if negation is in the presence of another negative element, it should not persist and should ultimately be canceled out so the resulting interpretation is positive. While this is not possible in NC languages, it is indeed the case in DN languages.

The contrast described is illustrated in Example (6), taken from Zeijlstra (2022) and adapted for the purposes of this thesis. In (6), we have one representative structure for two languages, one for Dutch in (6-a) which is a DN language; and (6-b) for Italian, an NC language. In Dutch, the negative marker *niet* together with *niemand* 'nobody' yield a positive reading, the two negations are thus canceled out. That, on the other hand, is not the case for Italian in which a similar negative marker *non* and *nessuno* 'nobody' yield a reading equivalent to a simple negated sentence.

(6) a. Suzanne belt **niet niemand**.
Suzanne calls NEG nobody
lit. 'Suzanne doesn't call nobody.'

int. 'Suzanne calls somebody.' (Dutch)

b. **Non** ha telefonato **nessuno**.
NEG has called nobody.NCI
lit. 'Nobody hasn't called.'
int. 'Nobody has called.' (Italian)

With the data in mind, we can say that in DN languages like Dutch, negation is inherently semantic. Due to this, the combination of any two semantically negative elements will always cancel each other out, as just seen in (6-a). By contrast, the same conclusion cannot be drawn for NC languages, and the status of negative elements remains to be debated, especially in terms of NCIs. In the eyes of many (Zanuttini, 1991, 1997; Laka, 1990; Giannakidou, 1998, 2000, i.a.), NCIs are viewed to be inherently negative and the effect of single negation interpretation requires a separate system of derivation. For example, Zanuttini (1991) and others perceive NCIs to be negative quantifiers that undergo negative absorption and thus form a single complex quantifier. However, in our approach, we will follow Zeijlstra (2004, 2022) and assume an underlying syntactic mechanism.

Zeijlstra (2022) argues that NC languages like Italian, illustrated in (6-b), exhibit *syntactic agreement*, i.e., a syntactic Agree operation between interpretable and uninterpretable features of clausal elements. Although in Italian, *nessuno* is said to carry semantic negation, in examples like (6-b) just discussed, it is devoid of this semantic negation and participates in the NC reading by carrying a [uNeg] feature, which must be checked off by another element, here the negative marker (NM) *non* that appears preverbally. However, when it is the NCI that appears preverbally, the structure can no longer contain the sentential negative marker *non*. This exact contrast will be crucial, as this distinguishes between Non-Strict Negative Concord languages, such as Italian, and Strict Negative Concord languages (Giannakidou, 2000), such as Czech, the language examined in this thesis. Next, we will go through these fundamental differences and proceed to Zeijlstra's account.

2.1 Strict and Non-Strict Negative Concord

Among NC languages, further variation is attested, specifically the distinction between *Strict* and *Non-Strict* NC languages. As already hinted in the previous Section, the main difference between these two types lies in the status of negative elements and ultimately, the conditions in which NCIs can appear in a clause.

For Strict NC languages, NCIs must always be accompanied by a negative marker no matter the configuration (Zeijlstra, 2022). Thus, it does not matter if the NCI appears preverbally or postverbally, it is always accompanied by an NM, as in e.g. Czech, Russian and Modern Greek. On the other hand, in Non-Strict

NC languages, the position of the NCI is what matters for the NM to be able to co-occur with the NCI. When an NCI is preverbal, it can no longer appear along with the NM. By contrast, when it appears postverbally, the NM is obligatory.

With this in mind, let us now turn to some examples from the languages just mentioned, again based on examples discussed in Zeijlstra (2022) and extended. In Example (7) for Czech, a Strict NC language, we see that no matter whether an NCI is postverbal (7-a) or preverbal (7-b), the presence of the verbal NM *ne-* is required. Thus, in Czech, to form a negative declarative sentence containing an NCI, such as *nikdo*, the verb must obligatorily bear an NM, the negative prefix *ne-* (the invariant form of verbal negation) and omitting it results in complete unacceptability.

(7) a. Včera *(**ne-**)volal **nikdo**.
yesterday NEG-called nobody.NCI
lit. 'Yesterday, nobody didn't call.'
int. 'Yesterday, nobody called.'

b. Včera **nikdo** *(**ne-**)volal.
yesterday nobody.NCI NEG-called
lit. 'Yesterday, nobody didn't call.'
int. 'Yesterday, nobody called.' (Czech)

Now compare Example (8) which shows equivalent structures in Italian, a Non-Strict NC language. In (8-a), the postverbal NCI is, as expected, obligatorily accompanied by an NM. This same NM, however, is forbidden when the NCI appears preverbally as in (8-b). In these cases, to have the NM *non* present yields an ungrammatical structure. Consequently, it is assumed that the NCI itself is inherently negative in these configurations; a claim that could not be made about any Strict NC language.

(8) a. Ieri *(**non**) ha telefonato **nessuno**.
yesterday NEG has called nobody.NCI
lit. 'Yesterday, nobody didn't call.'
int. 'Yesterday, nobody called.'

b. Ieri **nessuno** (*non) ha telefonato.
yesterday nobody.NCI NEG has called
lit. 'Yesterday, nobody didn't call.'
int. 'Yesterday, nobody called.' (Italian)

This suggests that the status of negative elements is fundamentally different even among NC languages themselves and deserves a theoretical explanation. Thus, in the next Section, we turn to the analysis by Zeijlstra (2022) who tries to account

for all of the data we have seen so far by positing a covert operator that enters into an Agree relationship with negative elements.

2.2 Zeijlstra's Analysis of Negative Concord

As pointed out in the previous Section, Zeijlstra (2022) treats negative concord as a syntactic process and assumes NC to be a case of syntactic agreement. Following the mechanism of Agree (Chomsky, 2000, 2001), Zeijlstra relies on a distribution of interpretable and uninterpretable features among negative elements and in many cases, an abstract covert negative operator $Op_{\neg}$. Assuming multiple Agree (Hiraiwa, 2001; Ura, 1996) these elements enter an Agree relationship during the derivation of a sentence, and the uninterpretable features are then checked off yielding a reading equivalent to a single negation, see the definition in (9). As NC languages differ among themselves, the proposed analysis differs in many aspects for Strict and Non-Strict NC languages. We will now take a closer look at how the analysis plays out in both types discussed.

(9) NC is an Agree relation between a single feature [iNeg] and one or more features [uNeg].

(Zeijlstra, 2022)

In Non-Strict NC languages, prominently in Italian we have seen examples of, the element bearing the interpretable negation feature [iNeg] is the verbal NM *non*. So as the theory predicts, in cases such as (8-a), where the negative element bearing a [uNeg] feature *nessuno* 'nobody' is below the NM bearing the [iNeg] feature and thus is available for agreement, a grammatical structure with an NC interpretation is yielded. If we maintain this premise, the reason behind the ungrammaticality of (8-b) becomes apparent. Since the [uNeg] element *nessuno* 'nobody' ends up in a position above the verbal NM where it is no longer c-commanded by the NM, an agreement relationship can no longer be established.

However, one still needs to account for the grammaticality of this structure without the NM. For these cases, Zeijlstra claims that a *covert negative operator* $Op_{\neg}$ is introduced. According to the author, the [uNeg] feature of the NCI is checked off *covertly* by an abstract operator $Op_{\neg}$ situated higher in the structure above the NCI, thus enabling an agreeing relationship.[2]

Figure 1 provides schematic tree diagrams for both derivations discussed above. On the left, Example (8-a) with a postverbal NCI is illustrated. The di-

[2]The reason for ungrammaticality of (8-b) thus might be twofold. As already mentioned, one reason is the position of the NCI, which is above the scope of the NM. Another reason is the clash between two elements bearing iNeg. If it is the position of the NCI that triggers the presence of $Op_{\neg}$, a situation arises in which both the $Op_{\neg}$ and the NM co-occur in one clause without giving rise to a DN reading.

agram on the right corresponds to the ungrammatical variant in Example (8-b) and shows the position of the covert $Op_{\neg}$ in a structure. In both diagrams, only the relevant interaction is captured and no specific attention is given to the exact structure beyond the relationship between the agreeing elements.

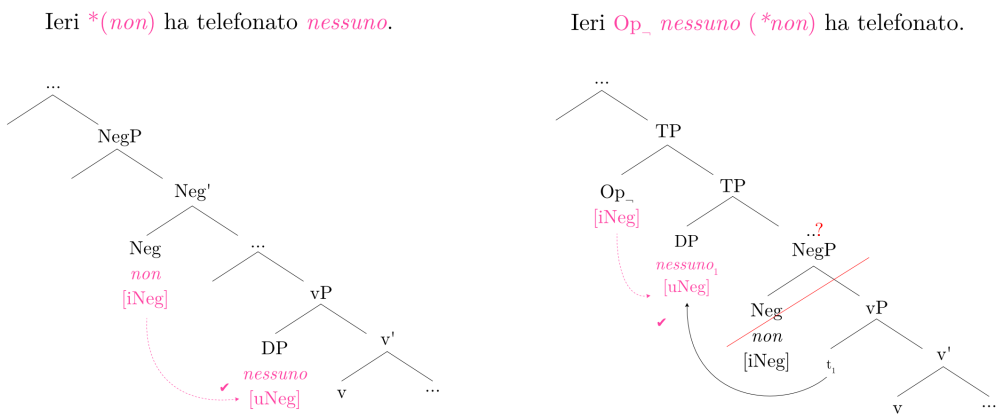

Figure 1: Schematic tree diagrams for Italian NC as syntactic agreement.

For Strict NC languages like Czech, Zeijlstra proposes that the only [iNeg] bearing element is the covert $Op_{\neg}$ which is present whenever the sentence is negated no matter the position of the negative elements. As Example (10) shows, in terms of position, it is possible to have both the NM and the NCI anywhere in the clause.[3] This leads Zeijlstra to assume that in Czech, both the NM and NCIs bear the [uNeg] feature which is checked off in the derivation by the covert $Op_{\neg}$. Since he takes the $Op_{\neg}$ to be an adjunct, it can thus appear anywhere high enough in the clause to check off all [uNeg] elements.

(10) a. Včera **ne**-volal **nikdo** (**ne**-volal).
yesterday NEG-called nobody.NCI (NEG-called)
lit. 'Yesterday, nobody didn't call.'
int. 'Yesterday, nobody called.'

b. (**Nikdo**) včera **nikdo** **ne**-volal (**nikdo**).
(nobody.NCI) yesterday nobody.NCI NEG-called (nobody.NCI)
lit. 'Yesterday, nobody didn't call.'
int. 'Yesterday, nobody called.' (Czech)

Schematic tree diagrams are again provided in Figure 2. On the left, a derivation in which the NCI follows the verb is captured, while on the right, there is the

[3] All positions are possible except for the initial position of the NM which will be discussed later in Section 3 in terms of polar questions, along with other examples.

same structure but with the NCI in a preverbal position. As expected, the $Op_{\neg}$ in both derivations is positioned above all negative elements and thus able to check off their [uNeg] features.

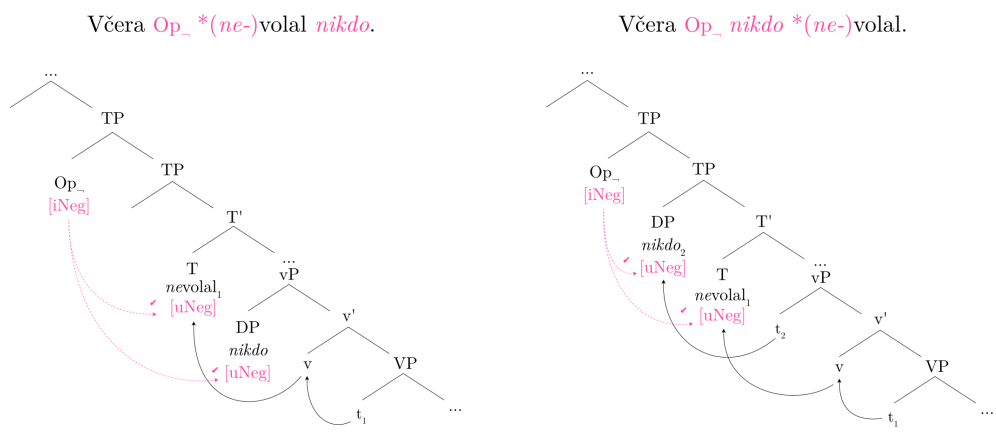

Figure 2: Schematic tree diagrams for Czech NC as syntactic agreement.

Given the different status of negative elements and what features they bear in the two types of NC languages, one may ask why the NM cannot be dropped when NCIs are present in a language like Czech. Since all negative elements bear a [uNeg] feature and the theory does not predict any other differences that would suggest the necessity of the NM, it would be predicted that a single [uNeg] element could be sufficient for the Agree relationship to take place.

Yet, we see the following pattern play out, see Example (11). In (11-a) for Italian, as already briefly discussed, structures with preverbal NCIs are expected to contain a covert $Op_{\neg}$ and thus disable the NM to appear in the structure. Although the $Op_{\neg}$ disables the NM, it does not disable the presence of other [uNeg] elements and thus, it is perfectly acceptable to utter a sentence like (11-a) with two NCIs. In Czech, however, to do so yields an ungrammatical structure. No matter the presence of the [uNeg] bearing NCIs, to not have the NM will ultimately be ungrammatical in every case, as in (11-b).

(11) a. Ieri **nessuno** ha telefonato a **nessuno**.
yesterday nobody.NCI has called to nobody.NCI
'Yesterday nobody called anybody.' (Italian)

b. *Včera **nikdo** volal **nikomu**.
yesterday nobody.NCI called nobody.NCI
int. 'Yesterday nobody called anybody.' (Czech)

But to have it the other way around for Czech is fully grammatical, see (12). Al-

though all negative elements bear essentially the same [uNeg] feature, the presence of NCIs in a negated structure seems to be optional, unlike what is seen for the verbal NM.

(12) Včera **ne**-volal.
yesterday NEG-called
'Yesterday he didn't call.' (Czech)

The reason behind this follows naturally from the fact that negative markers in Strict NC languages are said to be agreement markers in the most rigorous sense of the word. Analogously to null subjects in pro-drop languages of which Czech is a prime example, the NM is taken to be a morphological reflex of an $Op_{\neg}$ present in a structure and the negative marking is thus present even with a covert element like the $Op_{\neg}$. As the NM functions as an agreement marker, it thus cannot be dropped as other types of marker even when a previously covert element is present.

This is illustrated in Example (13), a mirror example of (12) with covert elements now present in parentheses. Observe that analogously to the case where the pronoun for the 3SG is dropped yet still reflected on the verb, the same can be said for negation. The $Op_{\neg}$ is covert, but still is reflected on the verb as an NM *ne-* due to its agreement marker status. Thus, it can be concluded that whenever we assume negation to take place in a structure, a covert $Op_{\neg}$ is present and ultimately reflected on the verb via the NM.[4]

(13) (On) včera ($Op_{\neg}$) **ne**-vola-l.
(he) yesterday ($Op_{\neg}$) NEG-called-3SG
'Yesterday he didn't call.' (Czech)

For the time being, let us assume the following for Czech. In Czech, all negative elements, i.e. the verbal negative marker *ne-* and NCIs such as *nikdo* 'nobody', bear a [uNeg] feature which is checked off by a covert $Op_{\neg}$ which bears the [iNeg] feature. The negative marker is a direct reflex of the presence of a covert $Op_{\neg}$. Although discussed only for assertions, all of the above is predicted by the theory to hold across constructions no matter their type, as the theory does not make different predictions for NCIs in declarative sentences as opposed to in other constructions such as questions.

However, as we have discussed the character of the NM, one question arises as to the status of NCIs. Zeijlstra himself claims that his approach falls under the negative polarity item (NPI) approaches in a broad sense, yet makes sure to make

[4]However, a question arises as to why in some languages, the covert $Op_{\neg}$ cannot be expressed via an overt element, as is the case for pro-drop languages where the subject can but might not always be expressed.

the divide between NPIs and NCIs in the theory. For him, NCIs are necessarily treated as part of the syntactic agreement relationship and thus, their licensing should be subject to syntactic constraints. In the next Section, we turn to this statement and discuss whether this prediction holds across relevant constructions mentioned in the literature along with some additional supporting arguments for the syntactic treatment of NCIs.

2.3 Drawing the Line Between NCIs and NPIs

The theory we have been building on so far assumes a fundamental difference between elements that we have referred to as negative concord items (NCIs) on the one hand, and negative polarity items (NPIs) on the other. Since the breaking point of Zeijlstra's proposal lies in NCIs' syntactic status, the point of the current Section is to provide data which show that this is indeed the case. In line with Giannakidou (1997, 1998); Giannakidou & Zeijlstra (2017), we firstly define the key characteristics of NPIs and, building on these observations, we then turn to individual cases which show that NPIs have different licensing conditions than NCIs. Then, by showing crucial data points from long-distance scrambling, we argue that syntactic treatment of NCIs is necessary in order to make correct predictions.

Broadly speaking, to understand the conditions in which any polarity sensitive item appears, it is first important to grasp the semantic properties of such environments. Generally, what has been noted in the literature is that negation and negative licensing conditions are said to be tiered. Thus, instead of having a dichotomy of a positive (veridical) or simple negative (antiveridical) environment, many cases demonstrate characteristics which are negative only to some extent, i.e., non-veridical such as questions, imperatives (non-negative), or downward entailment (minimally negative).

The extent to which an environment is negative is then responsible for licensing different kinds of NPIs which are referred to as *weak* and *strong NPIs*. As the name itself suggests, weak NPIs, such as *any* or *yet*, can appear in a broader range of environments, from non-veridical to antiveridical, while strong NPIs, like *either* or *in years*, are restricted to only a subset of those, mainly antiveridical ones. The definition of all licensing conditions is given in (14) based on Giannakidou & Zeijlstra (2017).

(14) VERIDICALITY OF FUNCTIONS

a. A function f entails p, it is veridical.
b. If f(p) does not entail p, f is non-veridical. → licenses weak NPIs
c. If f(p) entails not p, f is antiveridical. → licenses weak and strong NPIs

In accordance with the provided definition of possible licensing conditions, we can thus further define the notion of a negative polarity item as an expression which is negative-dependent, i.e., when an expression is sensitive to the extent to which the conditions are negative, we consider it to be an example of an NPI. In terms of the exact definition, we follow that of Giannakidou (1999), see (15).

(15) (NEGATIVE) POLARITY ITEM

a. A polarity item α is an expression whose distribution is limited by sensitivity to some semantic property β.

b. β is at least non-veridical.

To give a concrete example, consider (16) which shows an instance of both a non-veridical context in (16-a) and then an antiveridical context in (16-b). To establish a non-veridical reading, a downward entailing context signaled by *few* is used, i.e., given that there is *few* in the structure, it allows for set to subset inferences (will be explained in more detail in Section 2.3.1). As explained above, although weak NPIs such as *yet* are completely acceptable in both non-veridical and antiveridical contexts, the same cannot be said for the strong NPI *in years* which needs overt negation expressed by *n't*.

(16) a. *Few* students saw an eagle *yet*$_{\text{WEAK}}$/**in years*$_{\text{STRONG}}$. NON-VERIDICAL

b. Students did*n't* see an eagle *yet*$_{\text{WEAK}}$/*in years*$_{\text{STRONG}}$. ANTIVERIDICAL

The same holds for Czech, see (17). In equivalent structures consisting of a downward entailing context like (17-a) induced by *pár* 'few' and a simple negated one in (17-b), the weak NPI *sebemenší* 'slightest' is fully acceptable in both. Unlike the weak NPI, however, the strong NPI *ani* 'even' needs an antiveridical context with overt negation on the verb in order to be licensed.

(17) a. *Pár* studentů o tom mělo *sebemenší*$_{\text{WEAK}}$/ **ani*$_{\text{STRONG}}$ tušení.
few students about it had slightest.NPI/ even.NPI idea
'Few students had the slightest idea about it.'

b. Studenti o tom *ne*-měli *sebemenší*$_{\text{WEAK}}$/ *ani*$_{\text{STRONG}}$ tušení.
students about it NEG-had slightest.NPI/ even.NPI idea
'(The) students didn't have the slightest idea about it.'

To summarize the discussion so far, the licensing conditions for NPIs are strictly speaking always intertwined with the semantics of the respective environment and in many cases go beyond a simple negation that is expressed via an overt negative element in the structure. However, as noticed by many (Giannakidou, 2000; Dočekal, 2020; Dočekal & Dotlačil, 2024, i.a.), this is not the case for NCIs.

If we consider the definition in (18) by Giannakidou (2006), we arrive at a more formally anchored definition which heavily relies on the co-occurrence of another negative element. The crucial point is naturally that NCIs participate in the expression of NC, i.e., the expression of single logical negation discussed in Section 2. Additionally, though, which will shortly serve as one of the core examples of the divergence of NCIs and NPIs, NCIs can typically appear as fragment answers to questions, a characteristic not seen with either weak or strong NPIs.

(18) NEGATIVE CONCORD ITEM

a. α is an expression that can be used in structures that contain sentential negation or another α-expression, yielding a reading equivalent to one logical negation,

b. α can provide a negative fragment answer (i.e., without the overt presence of negation).

In a sense, NCIs and (especially strong) NPIs display similarities in terms of their licensing conditions, i.e. both mentioned technically need an antiveridical context which is marked by the presence of a negative element. However, in the remainder of this Section, we will take a closer look where the two diverge and thus attempt to delimit where NPIs stop and NCIs begin in Czech.

Building the argument up from non-veridical contexts which are favored by weak NPIs, we proceed to contextual conditions where only NCIs can appear and most importantly, arrive at a crucial case of long-distance scrambling, which will serve as an argument in support of NC as syntactic agreement. In terms of the examples discussed, they are taken from Dočekal (2020) and Dočekal & Dotlačil (2024) unless stated otherwise. The decision to use these examples is especially the fact that these constructions were tested experimentally and the judgements thus correspond to the experimental results in these studies.

2.3.1 Downward Entailment

Working off of Example (16) which demonstrated the licensing conditions of NPIs, we will further elaborate on the condition of downward entailment. As already mentioned, NPIs are not only sensitive to overt negation or broadly speaking, being in an antiveridical context, but their licensing conditions comprise other semantically marked contexts, downward entailment (DE) as a non-veridical context being one of them (Ladusaw, 1979; Giannakidou & Zeijlstra, 2017, i.a.).

Opposed to upward entailment in (19) which describes the relation between sets and their supersets, downward entailment means that if a relation holds for X, it will ultimately hold for any subset of X. Thus, as an entailment, whenever X is true, it will show as true for any subset, see (20) for an illustration. In (20-a),

it holds that if no dogs barked, it also has to be true that no dachshund (a dog of a certain breed) barked, since dachshunds form a subset of dogs. And logically, if something is not true for the subset, it does not have to be true for the whole set as in (20-b).

(19) a. A dachshund barked. $\vDash$ A dog barked.
b. A dog barked. $\nvDash$ A dachshund barked.

(20) a. No dog barked. $\vDash$ No dachshund barked.
b. No dachshund barked. $\nvDash$ No dog barked.

Following on the example above, negation is a common downward entailing context and thus, a typical licensor of NPIs. However, beyond negation, other contexts belong to this category, such as restrictive quantifiers like *at most* or *few*, or *málo* 'few' and *maximálně* 'maximally' in Czech already mentioned. Example (21) shows both a context with negation and a restrictive quantifier along with a weak NPI *any*.

(21) a. The students did*n't* see *any* birds.
b. The students saw (**any*) birds.
c. *At most two* students saw *any* birds.
d. At least two students saw (**any*) birds.

In Example (22), we will take a look at a similar structure in connection to NPIs together with NCIs, which seem to be inert to this semantic property. Just like in (16-a) mentioned earlier, weak NPIs such as *sebemenší* 'slightest' in Czech are licensed normally in a downward entailing context. *Málo* 'few' establishes the DE reading and in turn licenses the NPI. However, if we were to use an NCI *žádný* 'no' in this context, it would yield an unacceptable structure.[5]

(22) DOWNWARD-ENTAILING CONTEXT

a. *Málo* studentů mělo *sebemenší* šanci složit tu zkoušku.
few students had slightest.NPI chance to.pass the exam
'Few students had the slightest chance to pass the exam.'

b. #*Málo* studentů mělo **žádnou** šanci složit tu zkoušku.
few students had no.NCI chance to.pass the exam
'Few students had any chance to pass the exam.'

[5]A question arises as to why the structure is not viewed as completely unacceptable by speakers. One possible account of this behavior would be that the constituent here is viewed as focused, as can be e.g. seen in Greek with focused NCI constituents (Giannakidou, 2000). As this goes beyond the scope of this thesis, we leave the exact reasons to future research and argue for focus as one of the possible solutions.

(Dočekal, 2020)

Given the data in (22), it is thus clear that a semantically non-veridical context of downward entailment is not enough to license an NCI and thus provides one supporting argument for the divergence of these elements. Next, we will take a look at likelihood scenarios which are said to constitute one of the crucial NPI licensing conditions as well.

2.3.2 Likelihood Scenarios

It has been noted that beyond downward entailment, NPIs are also sensitive to pragmatic conditions on likelihood; see especially Crnič (2011, 2014) for a detailed discussion of *even* in connection with monotonic environments and likelihood. Simply put, the interpretation of a sentence in which an NPI appears must be less likely than the interpretations of the same sentence with any alternative expressions.

To demonstrate this condition, consider the acceptability of *even* in (23). In (23-a), *even one* is acceptable because the proposition entails all its alternatives: if the students did not read one book, it follows that they did not read two, three, or any greater number. The prejacent is therefore the least likely proposition in the set, satisfying the presupposition of *even*. The opposite holds in (23-b). Here, the alternatives (e.g. *didn't read 49 books*) entail the prejacent rather than the other way around, making the prejacent more likely than some of its alternatives. This violates the presupposition of *even*, yielding the sentence infelicitous.

(23) a. The students did*n't* read *even* one book. → LEAST LIKELY
⊨ The students did*n't* read *even* two books.
⊨ The students did*n't* read *even* three books.
⊨ ...

b. #The students did*n't* read *even* 50 books. → MORE LIKELY
⊨ The students did*n't* read *even* 49 books.
⊨ The students did*n't* read *even* 48 books.
⊨ ...

Example (24) illustrates this contrast with Czech data. In (24-a), *ani* 'even' is acceptable when Petr did not become a priest, because priesthood sits at the low end of an ecclesiastical scale: not becoming a priest entails not becoming a bishop, cardinal, or pope, making it the least likely outcome and satisfying the likelihood presupposition. By contrast, *ani* is infelicitous when Petr did not become a pope, since the papacy sits at the high end of the scale: not becoming a pope does not entail not becoming a priest, and the prejacent is therefore more likely than its

alternatives. The NCI *žádný* 'no', however, is fully acceptable in both contexts, demonstrating that NCIs are insensitive to these likelihood conditions.

(24) LIKELIHOOD SCENARIO

a. Petr se **ne**-stal ani knězem/ #ani papežem.
Petr REFL NEG-became even.NPI priest/ even.NPI pope
'Petr didn't even become a priest/pope.'

b. Petr se **ne**-stal **žádným** knězem/ **žádným** papežem.
Petr REFL NEG-became no.NCI priest/ no.NCI pope
lit. 'Petr didn't become no priest/pope.'
int. 'Petr didn't become a priest/pope.'

(Dočekal, 2020)

This constitutes a further empirical divergence between the two types of expressions. NCIs are inert to pragmatic likelihood, while NPIs are constrained by it. In the following section, we turn to a diagnostic that proves revealing especially for NCIs, namely their behavior in fragment answers.

2.3.3 Fragment Answers

As even the definition of NCIs in (18) provides, what is most typical for NCIs cross-linguistically is their ability to appear as fragment answers to questions, unlike NPIs, which are completely unacceptable in this use. This naturally follows in terms of both Zeijlstra's theory of NC as syntactic agreement and the general definition of NPIs given earlier.

First, referring to Zeijlstra (2004, 2022), we have established that for Strict NC languages, we assume a covert $Op_{\neg}$ which bears an [iNeg] feature and, given that it is an adjunct and precedes all negative elements, can check off their [uNeg] feature. The same assumption can be used to argue here. Since fragment answers are considered to be elliptic constructions, i.e., undergo deletion of clausal material, we assume the structure to contain, along with the NCI, an NM along with the covert $Op_{\neg}$. Thus, given that the operator is present above the NCI although the remaining structure is deleted, the NCI's [uNeg] is still checked off and yields a grammatical structure even as a fragment, see Example (25) for a schematic illustration.

(25) ✓[$Op_{\neg[\text{iNeg}]}$ [Nikdo$_{[\text{uNeg}]}$ ~~[ne-$_{[\text{uNeg}]}$ [přišel]]~~]]

Since the above analysis applies to NCIs only, it becomes clearer why NPIs cannot serve as fragment answers. In the definition in (15), NPIs are said to be sensitive to some property in the context while it stays true that this context must be at least non-veridical. Specifically for NPIs, however, these elements must be

overt in order for the NPI to be licensed in that context. Thus, no matter the structure before deletion takes place, the NPI in the fragment answer will end up ungrammatical. As for NCIs, see the NPI schematic derivation in (26).

(26) *[Ani$_{\text{NPI}}$ jeden ~~[ne- [přišel]]~~]

In terms of empirical data, this is exactly what we see play out, see Example (27). To the question *Kdo odešel z hospody?* 'Who left the pub?' in (27-a), to use the NCI *žádný* in *žádný student* 'no student' is completely grammatical due to the presence of the $Op_{\neg}$ discussed above. However, to use *ani jeden student* 'even one student' as an answer is ungrammatical.

(27) FRAGMENT ANSWERS

a. Kdo odešel z hospody?
who left from pub
'Who left the pub?'

b. **Žádný** student.
no.NCI student
'No student.'

c. *Ani jeden student.
even.NPI one student
'Even one student.'

(Dočekal, 2020)

In the next Section, we proceed to cases of neg-raising where syntactic locality is the crucial aspect in the use of NCIs and NPIs, which ultimately provides us with a stepping stone for a later case of long-distance scrambling in Czech.

2.3.4 Neg-raising constructions

Before getting into the details of NCI and NPI use in these constructions, we first need to establish the reason why these cases serve as a breaking point for the definition of these items in general. In order to do so, we first introduce the approach we take to neg-raising along with schematic derivations, and then proceed to examples.

At the core of the phenomenon of neg-raising lies the observation that with certain predicates such as *think*, *believe*, or *want* negation seems to 'raise' from an embedded clause to a matrix clause.[6] In other words, despite the negation being present in the matrix clause, it is interpreted at the embedded level, see Example (28) for an illustration.

[6]For a full classification of neg-raising predicates, we refer the reader to the work of Horn (2001) and others.

(28) [I do**n't** think [that you're right.]] = [I think [that you're **not** right.]]

Two main approaches have been taken towards this phenomenon. According to the first one, the reason behind the possibility of interpreting the negation in the embedded clause is due to syntactic movement taking place (Collins & Postal, 2014). Thus, in these structures, negation first originates in the embedded clause and then proceeds via cyclic movement to the position where it is pronounced, i.e. in the matrix clause, see (29). However, if we wanted to pursue this approach in the analysis of NCIs, it would make incorrect predictions, most importantly for the Czech data discussed shortly. For this reason, we lean towards the pragma-semantic account of neg-raising.

(29) [I do **not** think [that you are <**not**> right]]

(Collins & Postal, 2014)

The pragma-semantic approach (Bartsch, 1973; Gajewski, 2007; Zeijlstra, 2018, i.a.), on the other hand, argues that in neg-raising constructions, negation both originates and is pronounced in the matrix clause. The resulting interpretation of negation in the embedded clause is in fact a pragmatic effect of the presuppositional content of the matrix clause. Specifically, the embedded negation is derived as a semantic *excluded middle presupposition*. For a sentence such as the one in (28) which encodes that the subject either thinks p or $\neg p$, the negation rules out thinking p and then, enables the inference of *I think you're not right* where negation is interpreted in the embedded clause. The excluded middle thus allows for the embedded negation interpretation as a pragmatic enrichment of some sort, see Example (30).

(30) I do**n't** think you're right.

EXCLUDED MIDDLE PRESUPPOSITION
~~'I think you're right.'~~, 'I think you're not right.'

$\gg$ I think you're **not** right.

(Zeijlstra, 2018)

The position that neg-raising is a pragma-semantic phenomenon crucially plays out in the data, see Example (31). When the NM *ne-* is present in the clause embedded under *chtít* 'want', both the NCI *žádný* 'no' and *ani* 'even' are licensed. However, when negation originates in the matrix clause, and we assume that it does, it provides sufficient licensing conditions only for the NPI, i.e. the excluded middle presupposition is a sufficient licensor in this regard. The NCIs, on the other hand, need the NM to be present locally within one clause and thus, when

the negation is 'raised', the NCI is ungrammatical.

(31) NEG-RAISING CONSTRUCTIONS

a. Profesor Palný chce, abychom **ne**-vyhodili
professor Palný want COMPL NEG-expel.PST.1PL
žádného/ ani jednoho studenta.
no.NCI/ even.NPI one student
'Professor Palný wants us to not expel any/even one student.'

b. Profesor Palný **ne**-chce, abychom vyhodili
professor Palný NEG-want COMPL expel.PST.1PL
***žádného**/ ani jednoho studenta.
no.NCI/ even.NPI one student
'Professor Palný doesn't want us to expel any/even one student.'

(Dočekal & Dotlačil, 2024)

With this piece of data, we see the syntactic status of NCIs unfold. As discussed in the previous sections, NCIs are minimally sensitive to the semantic properties of the context as opposed to NPIs which depend on them. Neg-raising constructions then provide evidence that NCIs need the negative marker to appear in the same clause, no matter the excluded middle presupposition which allows negation to be interpreted lower than it originates. However, it is still evidence only from one direction. In the next Section, we take a look at long-distance scrambling in the attempt to move the NCI closer to the NM.

2.3.5 Long-Distance Scrambling

As an SVO language with a relatively free order of clausal constituents, Czech can display scrambling, i.e., free movement, both within one clause (Biskup, 2006) and across clausal boundaries, with interpretational consequences at the pragmatic level due to shifts in information structure. The latter, referred to as long-distance scrambling, will be in the center of our attention for the licensing of NCIs, i.e., when the NCI is moved from an embedded clause and ends up in the negated matrix clause via crossing the CP boundary.

Consider the following data from long-distance scrambling of NCIs and NPIs in Czech in Example (33). When the NCI is left in situ in the embedded clause as in (33-a), the absence of the NM in the clause renders the structure ungrammatical as seen in parallel structures in (31). However, when the NCI undergoes scrambling to the initial position of the matrix clause where the NM is present as in (33-b), the structure becomes acceptable. As for the NPI, however, no movement has any effect on its acceptability. Given the fact that we are again dealing with a neg-raising predicate, the NPI is licensed both in the embedded clause as well as

when moved to the matrix one.[7]

(33) a. *Petr **ne**-chtěl, aby Pavel koupil **žádnou** knihu
Petr NEG-wanted COMPL Pavel bought no.NCI book.ACC
Monice.
Monika.DAT
'Petr didn't want Pavel to buy any book for Monika.'

b. **Žádnou** knihu Petr **ne**-chtěl, aby Pavel koupil
no.NCI book.ACC Petr NEG-wanted COMPL Pavel bought
Monice.
Monika.DAT
'Petr didn't want Pavel to buy any book for Monika.'

c. Petr **ne**-chtěl, aby Pavel koupil ani jednu knihu
Petr NEG-wanted COMPL Pavel bought even.NPI one book.ACC
Monice.
Monika.DAT
'Petr didn't want Pavel to buy even one book for Monika.'

d. Ani jednu knihu Petr **ne**-chtěl, aby Pavel koupil
even.NPI one book.ACC Petr NEG-wanted COMPL Pavel bought
Monice.
Monika.DAT
'Petr didn't want Pavel to buy even one book for Monika.'

The approach we take in the analysis of long-distance scrambling assumes that real movement takes place, see (34). A constituent is thus base-generated in the embedded clause, where it e.g. gets case, and subsequently moved to the matrix

[7]In the examples discussed, the type of the predicate must be taken into account for acceptability. As already noted, a neg-raising predicate is essential at least for the full contrast of the acceptability of NPIs and NCIs in the embedded clause. However, the overall acceptability of long-distance scrambling itself is also dependent on the type of the verb, see e.g. Liu et al. (2022). Additionally for our examples, the thematic structure plays a role when a constituent like *žádnou knihu* 'no book' is moved to the matrix clause. If the constituent undergoes movement to a matrix clause that contains a verb which causes friction between the internal thematic structure of the verb, the acceptability of the overall structure is lowered. See the following contrast between the example seen and a structure with the predicate *myslet si* 'think' in (32-b). Another aspect to keep in mind for the resulting scrambled structures is that no matter the original word order before scrambling takes place, clitics have to be in the second position, as stated by the Wackernagel's Law (Wackernagel, 2020). Thus, when the constituent moved from the embedded clause will end up in the initial position as we will see shortly, the subject of the matrix clause will inevitably appear below the clitic.

(32) a. **Žádnou** knihu Petr **ne**-chtěl, aby Pavel koupil Monice.
no.NCI book.ACC Petr NEG-wanted COMPL Pavel bought Monika.DAT
'Petr didn't want Pavel to buy any book for Monika.'

b. ?**Žádnou** knihu si Petr **ne**-myslel, že Pavel koupil Monice.
no.NCI book.ACC REFL Petr NEG-thought COMPL Pavel bought Monika.DAT
'Petr didn't think that Pavel bought any book for Monika.'

clause, cf. accounts which assume the opposite, i.e., that a constituent is base-generated high and lowered at the LF (Bošković & Takahashi, 1998).

(34) **Žádnou** knihu Petr **ne-**chtěl, aby Pavel koupil <**žádnou** knihu> Monice.

Assuming this premise is on the right track, it should also hold that the movement is sensitive to other domains such as strong islands from which any movement, not just NPI or NCI, is blocked completely. Crucially, that is what we see played out in Example (35). There we see that when a constituent *knihu* 'book' is moved from an adjunct island, a because-clause, the movement is blocked and renders the structure ungrammatical. If we assumed that the constituent is instead base-generated in the matrix clause, the ungrammaticality in (35-b) would be unexpected.

(35) a. Petr šel spát, [protože Monika četla knihu do noci.]$_{\text{island}}$
Petr went to.sleep COMPL Monika read book to night
'Petr went to sleep because Monika was reading a book late into the night.'

b. *Knihu Petr šel spát, [protože Monika četla <knihu> do
book.ACC Petr went to.sleep COMPL Monika read book to
noci.]$_{\text{island}}$
night
'Petr went to sleep because Monika was reading a book late into the night.'

As the current data suggest, what matters the most for NCIs is the co-occurrence of the NM and ultimately the $Op_{\neg}$ within one clause. However, as some note for other NC languages (Kovač, 2026), the same restriction applies to NCIs when we take into account data of embedded predicates as well, such as infinitives. In the next Section, we thus turn to the data from Czech again with a focus on the licensing differences between NCIs and NPIs.

2.3.6 Embedded Predicate Extraction

As we have seen with embedded clauses and movement of the NCI to the negated matrix clause, the movement enables the NCI to become acceptable in an otherwise ungrammatical structure when left in situ. Crucially, this behavior is seen not only with embedded clauses, but also with embedded predicates such as infinitive constructions (see also Kovač (2026) who reports the same for Croatian NCIs). In a structure with an embedded infinitive, we assume the predicate to be a non-finite TP as captured in Example (36).

(36) [$_{\text{CP}}$ John$_i$ promised [$_{\text{TP}}$ PRO$_i$ to leave]]

If we were to create a similar construction in Czech and move an NCI out of the embedded TP, we would get similar results as already noted for embedded clauses in Section 2.3.5. When there is a negated embedded predicate that contains an NCI as a complement, e.g. *žádný* 'no' in all examples below, it is completely acceptable to have it within the TP no matter whether left in situ (37-a) or scrambled above (37-b). However, when this constituent is moved to the matrix TP, i.e. above *rozhodl* 'decided' as in (37-c), it yields an ungrammatical structure.

(37) a. Petr se rozhodl [$_{TP}$ **ne**-rozbít **žádný** hrnek].
Petr REFL decided NEG-to.break no.NCI mug
'Petr decided not to break any mug.'
b. Petr se rozhodl [$_{TP}$ **žádný** hrnek **ne**-rozbít].
c. *Petr se [**žádný** hrnek] rozhodl [$_{TP}$ **ne**-rozbít <žádný hrnek>].

Then, when the matrix predicate is negated, the pattern is observed to be the other way. To have an NCI within the embedded TP yields the structure ungrammatical due to the lack of the NM. However, when moved to the negated matrix predicate, the acceptability of such structure becomes progressively better. When the NCI appears at the edge of TP, it significantly improves the acceptability compared to the in situ position (38-b) and when moved to the position above the matrix predicate, it becomes fully acceptable (38-c).

(38) a. *Petr se **ne**-rozhodl [$_{TP}$ rozbít **žádný** hrnek].
Petr REFL NEG-decided to.break no.NCI mug
'Petr didn't decide to break any mug.'
b. ?Petr se **ne**-rozhodl [$_{TP}$ **žádný** hrnek rozbít].
c. Petr se [**žádný** hrnek] **ne**-rozhodl [$_{TP}$ rozbít <žádný hrnek>].

On the other hand, the data for NPIs in these exact structures show a significantly different pattern, see Example (39). In general, it is sufficient for the NPI to be in scope of negation, no matter whether the negated predicate is the matrix finite verb or the embedded infinitive. Unless the NPI appears completely above negation as in (39-c) or (39-f), the NM is sufficient to license it. Nevertheless, even in cases when the NPI is above negation, the overall acceptability is just lowered.

(39) a. Petr se rozhodl [$_{TP}$ **ne**-rozbít ani jeden hrnek].
Petr REFL decided NEG-to.break even.NPI one mug
'Petr decided not to break any mug.'
b. Petr se rozhodl [$_{TP}$ ani jeden hrnek **ne**-rozbít].
c. ??Petr se [ani jeden hrnek] rozhodl [$_{TP}$ **ne**-rozbít <ani jeden hrnek>].

d. Petr se **ne**-rozhodl [$_{TP}$ rozbít ani jeden hrnek].
Petr REFL NEG-decided to.break even.NPI one mug
'Petr didn't decide to break any mug.'

e. Petr se **ne**-rozhodl [$_{TP}$ ani jeden hrnek rozbít].

f. ?Petr se [ani jeden hrnek] **ne**-rozhodl [$_{TP}$ rozbít <ani jeden hrnek>].

Thus, unlike NPIs, which proved to be sensitive to semantic constraints in the contexts, NCIs remain dependent on syntactic locality both across the CP boundary and within one CP as shown above. As syntactic locality plays such a crucial role, we argue that a syntactic account for NC and NCIs is necessary and subsequent analyses should reflect this fact when trying to account for the data. Next, we will provide a summary of the data discussed and then, turn to data from polar questions which raise a number of questions regarding NCIs and their licensing.

2.4 Interim Summary

In this Section, we introduced the framework of Negative Concord as syntactic agreement proposed by Zeijlstra (2004, 2022). In his view, all negative elements in the structure bear a [uNeg] feature which needs to be checked off by an [iNeg] bearing element. In Strict NC languages like Czech, the [iNeg] bearing element is a covert operator $Op_{\neg}$ which appears as an adjunct high enough in the structure to check off features on all negative elements to yield a negative reading.

This assumption had consequences for both the negative marker and negative concord items. Firstly, for the NM, we thus assume that it is a reflex of the $Op_{\neg}$ present in the structure while having a non-negative meaning on its own. Secondly, for NCIs, we assume that their nature (although still under the NPI approach in the broad sense) is distinct from NPIs in the sense that they are not licensed semantically, only syntactically via a dependence on the syntactic locality with the NM. To show this, we employed a range of diagnostics to support this view, see 1 for a summary of the results.

Diagnostic	NPIs	NCIs
DOWNWARD ENTAILMENT	licensed	not licensed
LIKELIHOOD	sensitive	inert
FRAGMENT ANSWERS	not possible	possible
NEG-RAISING	licensed	not licensed
LONG-DISTANCE SCRAMBLING	licensed in situ	only if moved to the NM
EMBEDDED PREDICATE EXT.	licensed in situ	only if moved to the NM
LICENSING	semantic/pragmatic	syntactic (local NM)

Table 1: Summary of the licensing conditions for NPIs and NCIs in Czech.

Next, with a focus on the co-occurrence of the NM and NCIs, we take a look

at data from Czech polar questions. As we will see, polar questions obey the currently discussed principles in an interesting way. Although for NCIs in Czech, syntactic locality with the NM proved to be a crucial requirement, interrogative polar questions show that although the NM is within the same clause, the presence of an NCI yields an ungrammatical structure. Referring to the left periphery as a starting point for understanding this behavior, we will try to account for the data in Section 4.

3 Polar Questions

In the current Section, we will try to relate the data from Czech polar questions to the theory of Strict Negative Concord as introduced in Section 2. However, before doing so, we firstly need to elaborate on the examples introduced at the very beginning of this thesis 1 and show the data in their entirety especially with regard to the differences seen in canonical and non-canonical questions, since they behave in an opposite manner in terms of NCI licensing.

3.1 The Data

To summarize and extend what has been observed for declaratives in Czech, we have seen that NCIs are dependent on a locally expressed negation via the $Op_{\neg}$ and its reflex as an NM on the verb. This plays out in the data as illustrated by Example (40). As a typical Strict NC language, the NCI can appear either below the NM as in (40-a), above the NM in a subject position (40-b), or in both positions (40-c) while still yielding a single negative reading.

(40) a. Marek *(**ne**-)viděl **nikoho** z nich.
Marek NEG-saw nobody.NCI of them
'Marek didn't see any of them.'

b. **Nikdo** *(**ne**-)viděl Marka.
nobody.NCI NEG-saw Marek
'Nobody saw Marek.'

c. **Nikdo** *(**ne**-)viděl **nikoho** z nich.
nobody.NCI NEG-saw nobody.NCI of them
'Nobody saw any of them.' (DECLARATIVES)

As expressed in the examples above, to have the NM is obligatory and thus, whenever an NCI appears in a structure without negation, it is ungrammatical, see (42-a). Instead, the structures favor positive polarity items (PPIs) like *někdo* 'somebody' represented by (42-b). Just like negative polarity items are favored in the scope of negation or downward entailing contexts, PPIs are instead favored in positive contexts of upward entailment discussed in Section 2.3.1 in more detail. For this reason, the PPI *někdo* 'somebody' is highly dispreferred under a negated

predicate as in (42-c).[8]

(42) a. *Marek viděl **nikoho** z nich.
Marek saw nobody.NCI of them
int. 'Marek saw any of them.'

b. Marek viděl někoho z nich.
Marek saw somebody.PPI of them
'Marek saw some of them.'

c. *?Marek **ne**-viděl někoho z nich.
Marek NEG-saw somebody.PPI of them
int. 'Marek didn't see some of them.' (DECLARATIVES)

In interrogative questions, these licensing conditions are similar, see (43). In Czech, to form such questions, the finite verb is moved to the initial clausal position or, in other words, undergoes T-to-C movement as captured in Example (44) while displaying falling to rising (question) intonation. For positive questions, nothing changes with regard to the licensing of PPIs and NCIs. As in declaratives, PPIs are licensed in the usual way while NCIs are seen as completely unacceptable given they appear in a non-negative space.

(43) a. Viděl Marek někoho z nich?
saw Marek someone.PPI of them
'Did Marek see some of them?'

b. *Viděl Marek **nikoho** z nich?
saw Marek no.one.NCI of them
int. 'Did Marek see any of them?' (INTERROGATIVE QUESTIONS)

(44) [$_{CP}$ Viděl [$_{TP}$ Marek <viděl> někoho$_{PPI}$ z nich]]?

Crucially, the same pattern can be seen in negative interrogative questions, see (45). Although the NM is present in the structure within the same clause as a PPI or an NCI, the licensing conditions in negative questions resemble those of positive questions in (43). Thus, in (45-a), no matter the presence of the NM, the PPI *někdo* 'somebody' is licensed and opposedly in (45-b), the NCI which would

[8]We use 'dispreferred' to describe the example under discussion mainly because in some configurations, it is possible to have the PPI under negation. However, in these examples, the PPI has to be pronounced with prominence, see (41) for an illustration. Additionally, since PPIs behave as quantifiers in Czech, no matter their position, they still have to be interpreted above negation at the LF.

(41) Marek **ne**-viděl NĚKOHO z nich.
Marek NEG-saw somebody.PPI of them
'Marek didn't see some of them.' $\exists > \neg$

be expected to be licensed, is in turn not licensed and yields an ungrammatical structure. Thus, this behavior poses a significant challenge to the theory of NC as syntactic agreement. In the current example where negation seems to be present, at least superficially so, the NC relationship is broken.

(45) a. **Ne**-viděl Marek někoho z nich?
NEG-saw Marek someone.PPI of them
'Didn't Marek see some of them?'

b. *__Ne__-viděl Marek **nikoho** z nich?
NEG-saw Marek no.one.NCI of them
int. 'Didn't Marek see any of them?' (INTERROGATIVE QUESTIONS)

However, that is not the case for declarative questions, see (46). As non-canonical questions, they do not display T-to-C movement and the question interpretation of these utterances is instead read off from intonation which, similarly to interrogative questions, has a falling to rising contour, see e.g. Palková (1994); otherwise, their structure mirrors standard declaratives, see (40) and (42). Although positive questions do not license NCIs according to expectations (46-b), contrary to interrogative questions, negative declarative questions do license NCIs as would be expected (46-d). As for PPIs, however, the acceptability is lower, although not completely unacceptable.[9]

(46) a. Marek viděl někoho z nich?
Marek saw someone.PPI of them
'Did Marek see some of them?'

b. *Marek viděl **nikoho** z nich?
Marek saw no.one.NCI of them
int. 'Is it the case that Marek didn't see any of them?'

c. ?Marek **ne**-viděl někoho z nich?
Marek NEG-saw someone.PPI of them
'Marek didn't see some of them?'

d. Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho** z nich?
Marek NEG-saw no.one.NCI of them
'Marek didn't see any of them?' (DECLARATIVE QUESTIONS)

[9]As already noted for declaratives, we suggest that prosody may play a role here in terms of acceptability. Discussed prevalently for English data, semantic accounts have been proposed in terms of dedicated VERUM and FALSUM operators for verum focus in questions, associated with the licensing of NPIs and PPIs respectively. In addition to the current topic of polarity item licensing, these have to do with common ground management (Stalnaker, 1991) and bias expression. However, since this account relies on covert semantic operators which are at play at the licensing conditions, we set them aside for the purposes of the current thesis. As already noted in Section 2, we argue that negative concord and NCI licensing must be embedded in syntax, no matter the presence of semantic operators that are indisputably at play. For an in-depth discussion of these accounts, we refer the reader to the work of Romero & Han (2004); Repp (2013, i.a.).

Under responsive or rogative predicates like *ptát se* 'to ask', the pattern of these embedded questions is to some extent similar to that of declarative questions, see (47). In embedded questions, the initial position, i.e. in the CP, is occupied by a dedicated question complementizer *jestli* 'whether', so that any movement of the type seen in interrogatives is blocked as showed by a schematic representation in (48). As shown by the data, both PPIs and NCIs are licensed without any difference in acceptability.

(47) a. Ptal se, jestli Marek viděl někoho z nich.
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek saw someone.PPI of them
'He asked whether Marek saw someone.'

b. *Ptal se, jestli Marek viděl **nikoho** z nich.
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek saw no.one.NCI of them
int. 'He asked whether it is the case that Marek didn't see any of them'

c. Ptal se, jestli Marek **ne**-viděl někoho z nich.
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek NEG-saw someone.PPI of them
'He asked whether Marek didn't see someone.'

d. Ptal se, jestli Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho** z nich.
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek NEG-saw no.one.NCI of them
'He asked whether Marek didn't see anyone.' (EMBEDDED QUESTIONS)

(48) *[$_{CP}$ Ptal se, [$_{CP}$ viděl jestli [$_{TP}$ Marek <viděl> někoho z nich]]].

Furthermore, below the CP level of the clausal spine, embedded questions are insensitive to the position of the verb; the licensing of PPIs and NCIs is the same, i.e., both are licensed without differences in their acceptability, see (49) which shows the relevant examples of negated embedded questions.

(49) a. Ptal se, jestli (ne-viděl) Marek **ne**-viděl někoho z
he.asked REFL, COMPL (NEG-saw) Marek NEG-saw someone.PPI of
nich (ne-viděl).
them (NEG-saw)
'He asked whether Marek didn't see someone.'

b. Ptal se, jestli (ne-viděl) Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho** z
he.asked REFL, COMPL (NEG-saw) Marek NEG-saw no.one.NCI of
nich (ne-viděl).
them (NEG-saw)
'He asked whether Marek didn't see anyone.' (EMBEDDED QUESTIONS)

One question arises as to whether movement could be the reason behind the inability to license NCIs in interrogative questions in (45) and (43). More concretely, since the examples of declarative and embedded questions mentioned

above display the verb in a position below the CP level due to reasons of canonicity or occupation by a question complementizer, one may argue that it is the T-to-C movement that makes the NC reading unavailable. In the next Section, we turn to this claim and apply diagnostic tests to determine whether movement plays the key role here or whether more tools are needed to account for the data.

3.2 Is It Just Movement?

A question has been raised as to whether T-to-C movement is the key diagnostic for the anti-licensing of NCIs. Specifically, that the movement of the finite verb to C results in the verb being out of reach of the [iNeg] bearing $Op_{\neg}$ for it to check off its features and establish an NC reading which allows NCIs to take place.

However, as we will see in turn, this behavior is unexpected due to many reasons. Firstly, if the initial assumption of an out of reach position were on the right track, we would expect the structure to become completely ungrammatical whenever the NM is high, rather than solely unable to license NCIs. Since the verbal NM is a reflex of the covert $Op_{\neg}$ in the structure, it is unexpected for the NM to be present while not giving rise to the NC reading or NCIs yielding an ungrammatical structure as in a high negation question such as the one in (45), repeated here as (50).

(50) a. ***Ne**-viděl Marek **nikoho** z nich?
NEG-saw Marek no.one.NCI of them
'Didn't Marek see any of them?'

Furthermore, given that the $Op_{\neg}$ is proposed to be an adjunct that can move in the structure freely no matter the position of the negative elements, there is not a straightforward reason why it should not be positioned as an adjunct in the CP to check off the [uNeg] on a preposed verb or other elements in that position. Crucially so, this is exactly what we get in structures like the one in (51).

(51) **Nikdo** si **ne**-přečetl Petrovu magisterskou práci.
nobody.NCI REFL NEG-read Petr's Master's thesis
'Nobody read Petr's Master's thesis.'

Assuming that (reflexive and other) clitics such as *si* or *se* in Czech are always in the second position in the sentence (Wackernagel, 2020), and occupy a TP-external position (Lenertová, 2004), we assume that in constructions like (51), the NCI *nikdo* 'nobody' raises to the clause-initial position to yield the structure as it is captured in (51). Given that the sentence is grammatical, we can argue that along with the NCI, the $Op_{\neg}$ moves up above the NCI as an adjunct to check off the [uNeg] on *nikdo* 'nobody', see the schematic representation in (52).

(52) [$_{CP}$ $Op_{\neg[iNeg]}$ [$_{CP}$ **Nikdo**$_{[uNeg]}$ si [$_{TP}$ **ne**přečetl$_{[uNeg]}$ Petrovu magisterskou práci]].

Nevertheless, the ability to move negative elements to the CP is not limited to NCIs. As noted above when drawing the line between NCIs and NPIs in Section 2.3, one of the core arguments targeted long-distance scrambling. If we turn to scrambling but stay in local conditions, it is to some extent possible to move a (partial) VP into the CP layer, see Example (53) where the adjunct *před domem* 'in front of the house' and the negated verb *neparkuje* 'does not park' move yet still are able to license the NCI *nikdy* 'never' which is left in situ.[10] We thus assume the underlying movement captured in (54) where the verb undergoes movement to the CP yet an NC reading is still established.

(53) a. Petr před domem **ne-**parkuje auto **nikdy**.
Petr in.front.of house NEG-park car never.NCI
'Petr never parks his car in front of the house.'
b. Před domem **ne-**parkuje Petr auto **nikdy**.

(54) a. [$_{TP}$ Petr před domem **ne**parkuje **nikdy**].
b. [$_{CP}$ Před domem **ne**parkuje [$_{TP}$ Petr <před domem neparkuje> **nikdy**]].

At this point of the discussion, a reasonable question to ask would be targeted towards not having a context where the verb would appear sentence initially as the only constituent and thus, forming an equivalent structure to compare with interrogative questions. To achieve this, one can do so in a two-fold way.

The first way in Example (55) demonstrates a structure with a covert subject *Petr*. Since Czech is a pro-drop language, it frequently displays structures where the subject is reflected only via agreement on the verb, just like in (55-a) where the suffix *-l* is a reflex of a MASC 3SG subject. However, as represented in (55-b), it holds that the only possible way to do so is when the subject is covert; whenever it appears overtly, it disables the verb from appearing sentence-initially. If one were to position the verb sentence initially in a clause with an overt subject, it ultimately gives rise to a question reading which, in turn, disables NCIs from licensing (55-d).

(55) a. **Ne-**díva-l se **nikomu** do očí.
NEG-looked-MASC.3SG REFL nobody.NCI to eyes
'He didn't look into anybody's eyes.'

[10] As this topic goes beyond the scope of this thesis, we refer the reader to the work of Biskup (2006) who discusses the conditions under which a constituent or its parts can undergo scrambling in Czech.

b. Petr se **ne**-díva-l **nikomu** do očí.
Petr REFL NEG-looked-MASC.3SG nobody.NCI to eyes
'Petr didn't look into anybody's eyes.'

c. *__Ne__-díva-l se Petr **nikomu** do očí.
NEG-looked-MASC.3SG REFL Petr nobody.NCI to eyes
int. 'Petr didn't look into anybody's eyes.'

d. *__Ne__-díva-l se Petr **nikomu** do očí?
NEG-looked-MASC.3SG REFL Petr nobody.NCI to eyes
int. 'Didn't Petr look into anybody's eyes?'

What is important here, however, is the fact that in structures similar to those in (55-a), the NCI is licensed even with the verb in the CP layer. As noted above, since pronominal clitics are TP-external (Lenertová, 2004) and the first position is filled by a constituent raised to the left edge, it follows that the initial constituent, the verb or the subject in (55-b), has raised above the TP, see the schematic structure in Example (56). However, the position itself does not disable an NC relationship and NC takes place.

(56) a. [$_{CP}$ Nedíval se [$_{TP}$ nikomu do očí]].
b. [$_{CP}$ Petr se [$_{TP}$ nedíval nikomu do očí]].

Other than to have the subject covert, another possible strategy to construct an equivalent structure to questions would be to have the subject overt, but in a focused position (Groeben et al., 2017). To illustrate such a context, consider Example (57). In (57), the relevant construction is an answer to a wh- question which has the focused constituent sentence-finally and thus enabling the verb to appear sentence initially in CP as, again, the structure under discussion contains a clitic in C.

(57) Kdo si přečetl *Pýchu a předsudek*?
who REFL read pride and prejudice
'Who read *Pride and Prejudice*?'

a. **Ne**-přečetl si ji **NIKDO**.
NEG-read REFL her nobody.NCI
'Nobody has read it.'

Crucially, for both sets of examples where the verb takes the initial position in declaratives, it holds that a question intonation yields the structure ungrammatical due to NCIs in the structure and the inability of NC interpretation. Thus, if we were to take these examples and change the intonation only, judgments come out as follows in Example (58).

(58) a. **Ne-**díval se **nikomu** do očí.
NEG-looked REFL nobody.NCI to eyes
'He didn't look into anybody's eyes.'

b. ***Ne-**díval se **nikomu** do očí?
NEG-looked REFL nobody.NCI to eyes
int. 'Didn't he look into anybody's eyes?'

c. **Ne-**přečetl si ji **NIKDO**.
NEG-read REFL her nobody.NCI
'Nobody has read it.'

d. ***Ne-**přečetl si ji **nikdo**?
NEG-read REFL her nobody.NCI
int. 'Has nobody read it?'

The current discussion has shown that the movement of negation or, more precisely, the verbal NM within one clause does not break NC or the licensing of NCIs. Importantly, the initial hypothesis that T-to-C movement could be the breaking point for an NC interpretation has proved improbable as in Czech, there are numerous structures in which the verb appears initially in the CP layer and the NC relationship holds.

Thus, in line with what has been argued for in Section 2, we argue that the crucial aspect for NC is syntactic locality of the NM and NCIs and the reason behind the inability to license NCI in high negation questions has to lie someplace else. In the next Section, we thus turn to other characteristics of questions that could potentially account for the lack of NC, concretely with regard to the utterance type in general and how negation has been perceived so far in this type of utterances.

3.3 It Is the Utterance Type

Ending the previous Section, we have established that a surface structure can receive very different licensing conditions with regard to NCIs depending on the type of the utterance. Given these observations, it is thus desirable to lay down the characteristics of polar questions in order to differentiate between assertions where the NC relationship holds, and interrogatives where we see it break down.

In order to do so, we first need to characterize questions via the definitions we have argued for when discussing the differences between NPIs and NCIs and what it means for licensing other clausal elements like epistemic adverbs. This will further help us define the nature of negation in questions which, according to the diagnostics proposed by Greco (2019), can be classified as expletive negation. Given these facts, we will revise the proposal by Zeijlstra (2004, 2022) based on the facts from questions we have seen and engage with the left periphery as a potential answer to the unavailability of NC in questions.

3.3.1 Non-veridical and Non-negative

If we were to look back at the definitions in terms of veridicality given by Giannakidou & Zeijlstra (2017) (with reference to the author's previous work) from Example (14) repeated here as (59), we will ultimately also arrive at the defining properties of assertions and most importantly, of (polar) questions.

(59) VERIDICALITY OF FUNCTIONS

a. A function f entails p, it is veridical. → assertions
b. If f(p) does not entail p, f is non-veridical. → e.g. questions
c. If f(p) entails not p, f is antiveridical. → assertions

As for assertions, they can acquire two of the mentioned properties reflected in the definitions in (59). As assertions naturally express a commitment to the truth value of the propositions, they can either express a verity of such proposition which corresponds to a veridical context (59-a), or its falsity expressed by dedicated lexical items (e.g. *deny*) or overt negative elements which correspond to an antiveridical context (59-c). For an illustration, see Example (60), where (60-a) entails the truth of the proposition and (60-b) entails that the proposition is false.

(60) a. I saw the birds. $\vDash$ There are birds and I saw them.
b. I didn't see the birds. $\vDash$ There are birds and I didn't see them.

On the other hand, questions do not express such a commitment. Following Hamblin (1973), we assume that the denotation of questions is a set of potential answers, see Example (61-a) for an illustration. Thus, since a question denotes this set, it ultimately cannot entail the truth or falsity of a proposition (61-b). The resolution, or the commitment to a verity or falsity of the relevant proposition, is up to the interlocutor that provides the answer in the communicative situation, not the speaker themselves who utters the question.

(61) $[\![$Did you see the birds?$]\!]$

a. $= \{p, \neg p\}$
$=$ {'You saw the birds.', 'You didn't see the birds.'}
b. $\nvDash$ You saw the birds./You didn't see the birds.

This fact also follows from the classification in (62) based on Zwarts (1996) taken from Giannakidou & Zeijlstra (2017). Given this classification, questions together with imperatives and modal contexts form a category which is not only non-veridical, but also non-negative. In other words, they do not have any negative value, and thus they are one of the weakest licensors for NPIs and, possibly, also

for NCIs which are dependent on an NM that signals the presence of an $Op_{\neg}$.

(62) THREE KINDS OF NON-VERIDICAL CONTEXTS[11]

a. non-negative contexts (questions, imperatives, modal contexts);
b. classically negative (antiadditive or antimorphic);
c. minimally negative (DE but not antiadditive or antimorphic).

So far, we have only discussed questions in a broad sense, concretely that it constitutes a non-veridical and non-negative context. However, can this characteristic be extended to our cases of polar questions which are themselves negated? Going back to the denotation from (61) and more concretely (61-a), the denotation will have to be modified in order to account for negated questions.

Such an attempt is demonstrated in Example (63). Since we are adding propositional negation, we must assume that both propositions in the set denoted by the question are negated. However, as is illustrated by (63-a), this yields a denotation that is equivalent to the one in (61). Since negation of an already negated proposition results in a positive counterpart, the resulting set again consists of a positive and negative proposition. Thus, underlyingly, the two questions seem to be equivalent.

(63) ⟦Didn't you see that bird?⟧

a. $= \{\neg p, \neg\neg p\} = \{\neg p, p\}$
b. = {'You didn't see that bird.', 'You saw that bird.'}

Moreover, the same denotation can be seen when the negation is low, as in *Did you not see that bird?*. Since the negation ends up operating on the whole proposition, the underlying structure again results in a set equivalent to the one for a high negation question, i.e. $\{\neg p, p\}$.

This equivalence may explain why questions serve as the weakest licensor of NPIs even when negated. Another question opens up in turn as to what exactly is the purpose of negation in such questions and whether it really contributes negation in the same way as we have seen with assertions like declaratives where NC takes place. This is closely intertwined with epistemic expressions which receive a very different reading depending on the type of utterance in which they appear.

As Zanon (2025) notes, to determine whether a context is non-veridical, it is dependent on the ability to license the particle *slučaem* 'by any chance' in Russian.

[11] For the reasons of space, we leave out the discussion of other contexts, such as antiadditive and antimorphic, and focus solely on the non-negative context of questions. For a full discussion, see Giannakidou & Zeijlstra (2017) and the references therein.

According to her, this particle can only be licensed in polar questions discussed in this thesis, and then in conditionals, with negated perfective imperatives and under fear predicates.

This diagnostic of epistemic adverb/particle insertion can be extended to Czech. In Czech, *náhodou* 'by any chance' receives different meaning depending on the type of utterance. From the other meaning that translates to 'accidentally' or 'by accident' as in (64-a), and adversative meaning (64-b) which is linked to assertions, it gets the meaning of 'by any chance' in negated questions (64-c). Crucially so, this meaning is also associated with another non-veridical context, namely that of fear-clauses, see Example (64-d).

(64) a. Marek šel do toho vedlejšího bytu úplnou *náhodou*.
Marek went to that next-door apartment completely by.accident
'Marek went to the apartment next door completely by accident.'

b. On tu odpověď *náhodou* věděl.
he that answer in.fact knew
'In fact, he knew the answer.'

c. **Ne-**šel *náhodou* Marek do vedlejšího bytu?
NEG-went by.any.chance Marek to next-door apartment
'Did Marek go to the apartment next door, by any chance?'

d. Bojím se, aby Marek *náhodou* **ne-**šel do vedlejšího bytu.
I.fear REFL COMPL Marek by.any.chance NEG-went to next-door apartment
'I fear that Marek might go to the apartment next door.'

However, beyond non-veridicality, fear-clauses exemplified in (64-d) constitute a context which is said to employ expletive negation, i.e. negation that does not have any negative import yet still is expressed with a negative marker (Espinal, 2000, i.a.). Importantly, among other things, fear-clauses do not license NCIs just like we have seen for polar questions, see (65). Thus, a question arises whether the non-veridical nature of questions goes hand in hand with expletive nature of negation as is noted for fear-clauses. In the next Section, we will thus take a look at negation in polar questions through the lenses of expletive negation. Concretely, the focus of the Section will be to apply diagnostics which have previously been used to determine if a structure displays expletive negation, i.e. whether it is devoid of any negative content and whether it can be applied to the Czech data we have worked with so far.

(65) a. ***Ne-**šel *náhodou* **nikdo** do vedlejšího bytu?
NEG-went by.any.chance nobody.NCI to next-door apartment
int. 'Is it the case that, by any chance, nobody went into the apart-

ment next door?'

b. *Bojím se, aby **nikdo** *náhodou* **ne-**šel do
I.fear REFL COMPL nobody.NCI by.any.chance NEG-went to
vedlejšího bytu.
next-door apartment
int. 'I fear the case in which nobody would by any chance go to the apartment next door'

3.3.2 The Negative in Negation

By many, it has been noted that negation in questions constitutes an example of an expletive element, i.e., an element without a straightforward meaningful contribution. Thus, in the examples seen in the previous Section, we might even argue that negation does not contribute any negative import whatsoever (Greco, 2019, 2020; Tsiakmakis & Espinal, 2022; Tsiakmakis, 2025). However, it has also been debated whether this expletiveness holds across all structural layers. Specifically for questions, then, people have been extensively working on the pragmatic layer of polar questions, namely speaker bias (De Haan, 1999; Büring & Gunlogson, 2000; Romero & Han, 2004; Romero, 2015; AnderBois, 2019; Domaneschi et al., 2017, i.a.) which negation is said to primarily operate on.

Greco (2019) in his article summarizes characteristics of expletive negation which he then later uses as diagnostics to tell apart expletive and regular, standard negation which should contribute to the truth value of the proposition. In the remainder of this Section, we will try to determine whether Czech data discussed in this thesis pass the diagnostics of Greco (2019) for determining whether negation is expletive or not.

Firstly, Greco proposes that expletive negation (EN) should not reverse the polarity of the sentence in which it occurs as standard negation does (SN). Thus, turning to interpretation solely, positive and negative questions should be equivalent as for the meaning they convey.

This aspect changes significantly when taking into account all types of questions previously discussed, see Example (66) for a detailed description as for their respective meanings and possible interpretations. In interrogative questions in (66-a), negation is clearly not interpreted as a negative element when trying to paraphrase the content of the question. The speaker in (66-a) is not asking about a bird that was not seen, but essentially about the option that there exists a bird that was seen by *Marek*.

This cannot be extended fully to the possible interpretation of declarative questions in (66-b). In (66-b), both interpretations are possible, and one can only take it as a question with standard propositional negation that explicitly asks for a bird that was not seen. Embedded questions, on the other hand, can be

interpreted in two ways, see (66-c). Thus, it can be noted that only interrogative questions serve as a straightforward case of expletive negation.

(66) a. **Ne**-viděl Marek toho ptáka?
NEG-saw Marek that bird
'Didn't Marek see that bird?'
= I want to know whether it is the case that Marek saw that bird.
≠ I want to know whether it is the case that Marek did not see that bird.

b. Marek **ne**-viděl toho ptáka?
Marek NEG-saw that bird
'Did Marek not see that bird?'
≠ I want to know whether it is the case that Marek saw that bird.
= I want to know whether it is the case that Marek did not see that bird.

c. Ptal se, jestli Marek **ne**-viděl toho ptáka.
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek NEG-saw that bird
'He asked whether Marek didn't see that bird.'
= He asked whether it is the case that Marek saw that bird.
= He asked whether it is the case that Marek did not see that bird.

Secondly, Greco proposes that EN should not be able to license weak NPIs like *sebemenší* 'slightest', while at the same time legitimate PPIs like *někoho* 'somebody', take a look at the data in (67). In the context of high negation polar questions, to use *sebemenší* 'slightest' is almost completely unacceptable while PPIs are licensed normally in this context. However, in declarative questions (67-b) and embedded questions (67-c), NPIs and PPIs can both be licensed (and yield different interpretations).

(67) a. **Ne**-měl Marek ***?sebemenší**/ nějaké tušení?
NEG-had Marek slightest.NPI/ some.PPI idea
int. 'Didn't Marek have the slightest/some idea?'

b. Marek **ne**-měl **sebemenší**/ nějaké tušení?
Marek NEG-had slightest.NPI/ some.PPI idea
'Did Marek not have the slightest/some idea?'

c. Ptal se, jestli Marek **ne**-měl **sebemenší**/ nějaké
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek NEG-had slightest.NPI/ some.PPI
tušení.
idea
'He asked whether Marek didn't have the slightest/some idea.'

Additionally, the same generalization can be extended to strong NPIs as *ani jed-*

noho ‘even one’. As can be seen in Example (68), this is again something that is played out only in interrogative polar questions with high negation in (68-a). In negated declarative questions (68-b) as well as embedded questions (68-c), NPIs can be licensed freely. In all types, however, PPIs are licensed, to a certain degree, as usual.

(68) a. **Ne**-viděl Marek ***ani** **jednoho** člověka/ někoho?
NEG-saw Marek even.NPI one person/ someone.PPI
lit. ‘Didn’t Marek see even one person/someone?’

b. Marek **ne**-viděl **ani** **jednoho** člověka/ ?někoho?
Marek NEG-saw even.NPI one person/ someone.PPI
lit. ‘Did Marek not see even one person/someone?’

c. Ptal se, jestli Marek **ne**-viděl **ani** **jednoho** člověka/ někoho.
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek NEG-saw even one person/ someone.PPI
‘He asked whether Marek didn’t see even one person/someone.’

Based on the observations of Delfitto & Fiorin (2014) and Chierchia (2013), Greco proposes specifically for Italian that EN does not license the conjunction *e* ‘and’ and the negative word *neanche* lit. ‘not-also’, but only the conjunction *e* ‘and’ and the word *anche* ‘also’.

In Czech, this could be considered as potentially equivalent to the additive conjunction *i* ‘and’ (Dočekal & Šafratová, 2018) which roughly corresponds to *e anche*, and *ani* ‘nor’ which is similar to *e neanche*. When used in questions under discussion, see that the pattern is again the same. In interrogative questions, only the *i* conjunction can be used while *ani* is considered to be completely unacceptable. Again, in declarative questions and embedded questions, both conjunctions mentioned are fine, see (69-b) and (69-c).

(69) a. **Ne**-viděl Marek Alexe *i/* (**ani*) Anetu?
NEG-saw Marek Alex and/ nor Aneta
lit. ‘Didn’t Marek see Alex and/nor Aneta?’

b. Marek **ne**-viděl Alexe *i/* *ani* Anetu?
Marek NEG-saw Alex and/ nor Aneta
lit. ‘Marek didn’t see Alex and/nor Aneta?’

c. Ptal se, jestli Marek **ne**-viděl Alexe *i/* *ani* Anetu.
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek NEG-saw Alex and/ nor Aneta
‘He asked whether Marek didn’t see Alex and/nor Aneta.’

Lastly, Greco assumes that the inability to license NCIs and establish an NC reading is another supporting argument for the expletive nature of negation. As we

have already seen and discussed, the data show that the inability to do so is again seen only in interrogative questions. Elsewhere, the NC reading is always available, see (70).

(70) a. **Ne**-viděl Marek ***nikoho**/ někoho z nich?
NEG-saw Marek nobody.NCI/ someone.PPI from them
'Didn't Marek see any/some of them?'

b. Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho**/ někoho z nich?
Marek NEG-saw nobody.NCI/ someone.PPI from them
'Did Marek not see any/some of them?'

c. Ptal se, jestli Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho**/ někoho
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek NEG-saw nobody.NCI/ someone.PPI
z nich.
from them
'He asked whether Marek didn't see any/some of them.'

However, with regard to the diagnostics applied here, it is important to note that the results of their application may only point us a certain direction with regard to the expletive nature of negation in questions. Especially when it comes to strong NPIs and the conjunction diagnostics, it is arguable whether it should not constitute a single test. Since the conjunction is sensitive to the negative properties of the context in which it appears, it seems that it is inherently also an NPI and thus does not demonstrate any significant observations that go beyond what has been previously discussed.

Nonetheless, even when we raise these objections, the diagnostics reveal a significant asymmetry beyond NCI licensing in different types of questions, see the summary in Table 2. Concretely, it seems that interrogative questions do not have any negative import whatsoever since they do not license any kind of NPIs and when paraphrased, their interpretation corresponds to a positive question. It thus seems that interrogative questions behave in a completely opposite manner to their declarative counterparts and furthermore, when the question is embedded.

	Question type		
Diagnostic	Interrogative	Declarative	Embedded
NEGATIVE INTERPRETATION	✗	✓	✓
NPI LICENSING	✗	✓	✓
'ANI' CONJUNCTION LICENSING	✗	✓	✓
NCI LICENSING	✗	✓	✓

Table 2: Summary of the diagnostics of expletive negation applied to Czech polar questions.

3.3.3 Evaluative Negation

One more thing can be noted here with reference to the optionality of negation in these utterances. It has been noted in the literature that if negation is expletive, it necessarily carries additional pragmatic meaning (Espinal, 2000; Tsiakmakis & Espinal, 2022). As we have continuously argued for interrogative questions that the negation might be expletive, we should see these pragmatic effects play out. Crucially, this is exactly what we see in Czech (Staňková, 2023; Šimík, in press) as well as cross-linguistically (Büring & Gunlogson, 2000; De Haan, 1999; Romero & Han, 2004, i.a.).

Consider Example (71) for a demonstration. In the context, the speaker Monika is convinced that her friend Marek should be at a Sunday farmers market, since that is what he usually does that day. For that reason, she decides to invite him for a cup of coffee to a nearby café. However, when they talk on the phone, she is told that he is at the gym and thus cannot make it. In reaction to this, she asks a question that is negated, see (71-a). Negation in this question is said to carry a bias, namely a positive epistemic bias, i.e. a bias towards the positive proposition 'You went to the farmers market.' based on a prior belief the speaker had before the time of utterance (Sudo, 2013). Although it is completely felicitous to utter this question as positive, when negation is added, it inherently expresses this bias.

(71) Since *Monika knows that Marek usually goes to the farmers market on Sundays*, she decides to give him a call to invite him to have a cup of coffee in a café near this market. Monika asks Marek on the phone:

a. (**Ne-**)jdeš dneska zase na trhy?
NEG-go today again on market
'Don't you go to the market again today?'

It is thus suggested by this behavior that negation, at least in interrogative questions, serves as an optional expletive element which bears a meaning associated with speaker bias or possibly the level of certainty regarding the truth of the proposition, something referred to by many as *evaluative negation* (Yoon, 2011; Tsiakmakis & Espinal, 2022; Dimitrova, 2022; Baunaz & Demonie, 2025). This view is supported by data from other languages as well. Especially for Modern Greek, a language which distinguishes between expletive negation and standard negation by a different lexical item, it has been observed that expletive negation is widely attested in polar questions along with standard negation while yielding different interpretations for both respectively.

To demonstrate the difference, take a look at Example (72) taken from Tsi-

akmakis (2025) and adjusted for the purposes of this thesis. In Modern Greek interrogative polar questions, to use the expletive negation marker *min* yields an interpretation that, as indicated by *maybe* in the translation, corresponds to a biased question in the sense described above. Concretely, the question is biased towards the proposition 'Dad ate the meatball soup.'. Importantly, it cannot license NCI such as *tipota* 'nothing', similarly to what we have seen for Czech polar questions (72-a).

However, when the regular negation marker *dhen* is added to the proposition, it introduces sentential negation which is able to license NCIs normally and ultimately yields a negative interpretation, i.e., a question which specifically asks about dad not eating any soup (72-b). However, the only way to achieve this reading is to have the sentential negation above the marker we have referred to as expletive negation. To have it above yields the structure ungrammatical, see (72-c).

(72) a. **Min** efaye ta yuvarlakia/ ***tipota** o babas?
ExpNeg ate the meatball.soup nothing.NCI the dad
'Did dad maybe eat the meatball soup/nothing?'

b. **Min** **dhen** efaye ta yuvarlakia/ **tipota** o babas?
ExpNeg RegNeg ate the meatball.soup nothing.NCI the dad
'Did dad maybe not eat the meatball soup/anything?'

c. ***Dhen** **min** efaye ta yuvarlakia o babas?
RegNeg ExpNeg ate the meatball.soup the dad
'Did dad maybe not eat the meatball soup?'

Generally for Modern Greek, expletive negation *min* is only available when positioned high, see Example (73) from Tsiakmakis (2025). In fear-clauses, expletive *min* cannot be preceded by informationally unmarked subjects (73-a). Unless they are topicalized or possibly focused, they can only appear post-verbally as in (73-b).

(73) a. *Fovame o babas **min** efaye yuvarlakia.
I.fear the dad ExpNeg ate meatball.soup
'I fear that dad maybe ate the meatball soup.'

b. Fovame **min** efaye yuvarlakia o babas.
I.fear ExpNeg ate meatball.soup the dad
'I fear that dad maybe ate the meatball soup.'

Tsiakmakis (2025) considers these facts to mean that expletive negation is merged high above TP associated with asserted material. Concretely, with reference to the left periphery, he proposes that expletive negation resides in a structurally higher position where projections associated with the speaker's judgment of the

truth of the proposition reside.

If we considered that an equivalent process happens in Czech, we would expect polar questions to show similar patterns as in (72). However, in Czech, the pattern observed cannot be equivalent as a whole, since Czech does not employ NM as a separate head, but rather a prefix that moves simultaneously with the verb. For this reason, within one structural spine, we should consider having two verbal heads that negation can attach to, namely a modal verb *mít* 'should' and a lexical verb *jít* 'go', see Example (74).

In a negated interrogative when only the modal verb in C holds negation, it is again interpreted as not bringing the negative import and thus, cannot license any NCIs (74-a), which is reminiscent of the *min*'s inability to license NCIs in (72-a). However, when the lexical verb is negated as well as in (74-b), not only is the negation itself interpreted in the question, but it can also license NCIs such as *nikam* 'nowhere'. Ultimately, in these configurations where two NMs are present, we would get a DN reading such as exemplified in (74-c) in an assertion. This follows because each NM that reflects the presence of an $Op_{\neg}$ contributes a semantic negation, so two such markers cancel out; the absence of this cancellation in the interrogative shows that the matrix NM does not reflect the $Op_{\neg}$.

(74) a. **Ne**-měl táta jít do práce/ (***nikam**)?
NEG-should dad to.go to work/ nowhere.NCI
'Shouldn't dad go to work/ nowhere?'

b. **Ne**-měl táta **ne**-jít do práce/ **nikam**?
NEG-should dad NEG-to.go to work/ nowhere.NCI
'Shouldn't dad not go to work/ nowhere?'

c. Táta **ne**-měl **ne**-jít do práce/ **nikam**.
dad NEG-should NEG-to.go to work/ nowhere.NCI
'Dad shouldn't not go to work/ nowhere.'

This split can also be seen in other Slavic languages beyond Czech, e.g., in Bulgarian (Dimitrova, 2022), Russian (Gribanova, 2017; Zanon, 2025) and Serbian (Todorović, 2024). Although the data do not cover the same dataset of questions, when it comes to the interrogative lack of NCI licensing, the patterns look equivalent to what has been seen in Czech, see (75).

(75) a. Ivan **ne** kupi li nešto/ ***ništo**?
Ivan NEG bought QPART something.PPI/ nothing.NCI
int. 'Didn't Ivan buy something/anything?'

Bulgarian, adapted from Dimitrova (2022)

b. ***Ne** kupil (li) **ničego** Petr?
NEG bought QPART nothing Petr
int. 'Didn't Petr buy anything?'

Russian, adapted from Zanon (2025)

c. **Ne** večeraju li deca išta/ ***ništa**?
NEG dine QPART kids anything.NPI/ nothing.NCI
int. 'Aren't the kids eating anything/nothing for dinner?'

Serbian, adapted from Todorović (2024)

Since negation in high negation polar questions in Czech seems to resemble similar patterns as in other languages, in the next Section, following Tsiakmakis (2025), we will take a look at the Left Periphery of the clausal spine (Cinque, 1999; Rizzi, 1997; Krifka, 2020, 2021, 2024) as a potential answer to the inability to license NCI in high negation polar questions. Building off of assertions and their structure, we proceed to questions and what differences internally distinguish between interrogative and declarative questions, and possibly between embedded questions as well.

3.4 The Left Periphery

Following on the observations and analysis proposed by Tsiakmakis (2025), we further engage with the idea of the Left Periphery as an account that could explain the data of Czech polar questions within the framework of NC as syntactic agreement. To do so, we build on the proposal by Krifka (2020, 2021, 2024) who, working up the arguments primarily on data from German, claims that the pragmatic layer is encoded in the left periphery in syntax, namely above TP.

3.4.1 Krifka's Proposal for Assertions

Based on his initial proposal (Krifka, 2015) later developed for assertions, Krifka (2020, 2024) builds on the idea that in syntactic representation, there are multiple layers above TP which encode notions associated with a pragmatic, contextually dependent layer for which it was usually claimed that it is not hard-coded in grammar. However, based primarily on the restrictions put on modifiers, or epistemic adverbs which convey speakers' attitudes toward a proposition, and embedding which mirrors projections present in the structure, he develops arguments which support that the Left Periphery of syntactic spine is subject to hosting different elements than those that occur in a TP layer of a clause.

The crucial idea at the core of this proposal is linked to commitment to the truth of the proposition. As opposed to questions which are to be discussed in more detail in turn, assertions are thus said to necessarily be associated with a public commitment of the speaker that a certain proposition is true. To support this, Krifka (2020) argues with Moore's Paradox (Moore, 1942) as one of the supporting arguments, see Example (76) for an illustration. In a situation where a speaker utters (76), it results in a contradiction. Since assertions assume the

speaker to commit to the truth of the proposition, to not believe the proposition itself results in a contradiction infelicitous to utter.[12]

(76) #Max is snoring, but I don't believe it.

Due to this broader characteristic of assertions, a separate commitment projection is thus proposed and said to reside right above the TP layer that comprises the propositional content to which the speaker commits. Especially relevant for the question-statement opposition, Krifka (2020) also assumes a projection that encodes the type of the speech act and lastly, a projection which encodes a personal stance, or private judgments in Krifka's words, towards the truth of the proposition.

A structure in which all of these projections take place in German is demonstrated by Example (77), taken from the article. See that all of these projections mentioned above are positioned above the TP with their heads final to mirror the head-final nature of German, as will be seen in turn. In assertions, the head of ComP is a turnstile that signals the public commitment while in the head of JP, there is a 'J–' sign which represents that the speaker judges the proposition to be true. Since Krifka assumes that in assertive clauses, both the head and the specifier of ActP have to be filled, we get the following clausal structure as captured in (77-b).

(77) a. $[_{ActP}\ [_{Act'}\ [_{Act^{o}}\ \bullet\ ]\ [_{ComP}\ [_{Com'}\ [_{JP}\ [_{J'}\ [_{TP}$ Max laut schnarcht$]\ [_{J^{o}}$ J–$]]\ [_{Com^{o}}\ \vdash]]]]]]$
'Max is snoring loudly.'

b. $[_{ActP}$ Max$_1$ $[_{Act'}\ [_{Act^{o}}$ schnarcht$_0$ $\bullet]\ [_{ComP}$ t$_1$ $[_{Com'}\ [_{JP}$ t$_1$ $[_{J'}\ [_{TP}$ t$_1$ laut t$_0]$ $[_{J^{o}}$ t$_0$ J–$]]\ [_{Com^{o}}$ t$_0$ $\vdash]]]]]]$
'Max is snoring loudly.'

To assume the presence and this specific order of these projections, Krifka develops two main arguments which gravitate around epistemic adverbs. See that in (77-b), an assertive clause is captured while having its JP unoccupied by any lexical material whatsoever. Krifka claims that this position can only be filled by items which are related to epistemic or evidential modifications of the proposition that the speaker is committed to. At least in terms of the proposal discussed, epistemic modification is related to the certainty of the speaker with regard to the truth of the proposition, and evidential modification is related to the source of evidence for the proposition, or the evidence to commit to the truth of the

[12]However, see Krifka (2020) for the whole argument which explains this oddity with other reasoning as well.

proposition. Next, we turn to some evidence for these projections using these adverbs.[13]

As for the JP, the main argument is based on a comparison between subject epistemic adverbs expressing certainty, such as *sicherlich* 'certainly', and so-called objective epistemic adjectives like *sicher* 'certain' which are to reside in the TP layer of a clause as a predicate. In constructions which introduce a TP, such as the protasis of a conditional, i.e., the if-clause of the sentence, to use an epistemic adverb is considered to be considerably less acceptable than to use the epistemic adjective. This difference is demonstrated by Example (78), where epistemic adverbs such as *sicherlich* 'certainly' or *wahrscheinlich* 'probably' in (78-a) are judged to be less suitable than their adjective counterparts in (78-b).

(78) a. Wenn Max ??*sicherlich/* ?*wahrscheinlich* schnarcht, sollten wir
if Max certainly/ probably snores should we
Ohrstöpsel mitnehmen.
earplugs bring
'If Max is certainly/probably snoring, we should bring earplugs.'

b. Wenn es *sicher/ wahrscheinlich* ist, dass Max schnarcht, sollten
if it certain/ probable is COMPL Max snores should
wir Ohrstöpsel mitnehmen.
we earplugs bring
'If it's certain/probable that Max is snoring, we should bring earplugs.'

Additionally, it should also hold that negation cannot scope over epistemic nor evidential adverbs, see Example (79). Unlike *sicher* 'certain', *sicherlich* 'certainly' cannot be in scope of sentential negation *nicht* as in (79-a) and yields an ungrammatical structure.

(79) a. *Max schnarcht *nicht sicherlich/ unsicherlich* laut.
Max snores NEG certainly/ uncertainly loudly
lit. 'Max is not certainly/ uncertainly snoring loudly.'

b. Es ist *nicht sicher/ unsicher*, ob Max laut schnarcht.
it is NEG certain/ uncertain whether Max loudly snores
lit. 'It's not certain/ uncertain whether Max snores loudly.'

The reasoning behind the presence of the ComP, which hosts expressions that strengthen the commitment of the speaker, goes hand in hand with the examples seen for the JP. Since we assume that epistemic adverbs seen earlier reside in the JP, it should hold that expressions hosted in a projection above should also

[13]For the reasons of space, we dedicate this Section only to a limited set of the diagnostics proposed by Krifka (2020) and therefore refer the reader to the article mentioned and the references therein which further support this view.

take scope over those adverbs, not vice versa. Crucially, this is exactly what we see play out, see Example (80), where the adverb *wahrlich* 'truly' which expresses commitment of the speaker, should always precede epistemic or evidential elements like the expression *mit Sicherheit* 'with certainty' below.

(80) a. Dieses Buch ist *wahrlich mit Sicherheit* ein Meisterwerk.
this book is truly with certainty a masterpiece
'This book is truly with certainty a masterpiece.'

b. *Dieses Buch ist *mit Sicherheit wahrlich* ein Meisterwerk.
this book is with certainty truly a masterpiece
int. 'This book is truly with certainty a masterpiece.'

The same scope interaction is present between ActP and both ComP and JP, see Example (81). As for ActP, expressions that are hosted in this projections should modify the speech act, or in other words, should point out to the speech act that is expressed by the utterance or indicate a relation of the utterance towards the rest of the discourse, such as *übrigens* 'by the way' presented in the Example below. Thus, it is ungrammatical to use such an expression so that it scopes below an epistemic or evidential adverb (81-b), or a commitment expression (81-d).

(81) a. Max schnarcht *übrigens ungelogen* sehr laut.
Max snores by.the.way honestly very loudly
'By the way, Max honestly snores very loudly.'

b. *Max schnarcht *ungelogen übrigens* sehr laut.

c. Max schnarcht *übrigens mit Sicherheit* sehr laut.
Max snores by.the.way with certainty very loudly
'Frankly, Max certainly snores very loudly.'

d. *Max schnarcht *mit Sicherheit übrigens* sehr laut.

As the data suggest, it seems that all of the above modifications reside in the Left Periphery in a dedicated projection that corresponds to the type of the expression and its relation to the proposition from the side of the speaker. However, as in the center of the thesis lie data from Czech, it is desirable for this proposal to be extended beyond the German dataset. In line with the current proposal then, we can work up the structure in Example (82) for the time being of this Section. See that since Czech is a head-initial language, unlike German which has both head-final and head-initial properties, the heads of ComP and JP also dispose of a left-adjusted position.

(82) a. $[_{ActP}$ $[_{Act'}$ $[_{Act^{o}}$ •] $[_{ComP}$ $[_{Com'}$ $[_{Com^{o}}$ ⊢] $[_{JP}$ $[_{J'}$ $[_{J^{o}}$ J–] $[_{TP}$ Marek chrápe nahlas]]]]]]
'Marek is snoring loudly.'

If we were to motivate the structural positions in the same manner as was argued for German by Krifka (2020), we would arrive at similar conclusions with regard to acceptability. In terms of conditional protasis in Example (83), to use epistemic or evidential adverbs is not possible without an interpretational shift. Adverbs like *jistě* 'certainly' in (83-a) can, without any intonational shifts, only be interpreted such as Marek was confident while snoring, i.e. since *jistý* 'certain' can also be used as 'confident', this reading is the most salient when the adverb is interpreted in TP. However, objective epistemic adjectives are used normally in this context (83-b).

(83) a. ??Pokud Marek *jistě/ pravděpodobně* chrápe, měli bychom
if Marek certainly/ probably snores should AUX
si vzít špunty do uší.
REFL to.bring plugs to ears
'If Marek certainly/probably snores, we should bring earplugs.'

b. Pokud je jisté/ pravděpodobné, že Marek chrápe, měli
if is certain/ probable COMPL Marek snores should
bychom si vzít špunty do uší.
AUX REFL to.bring plugs to ears
'If it's certain/probable that Marek snores, we should bring earplugs.'

However, when it comes epistemic adverbs in scope of negation, we get results that correspond to German data only partly, see Example (84). Since negation can only be borne out as an NM on the verb and thus cannot scope below the verb while above the adverb as in German (79), it only becomes less acceptable. However, even in this construction, the adverb needs to receive a more prominent prosody for it to be able to get the epistemic reading.

(84) a. ?Marek ne-chrápe *jistě* nahlas.
Marek NEG-snores certainly loudly
lit. 'Marek doesn't certainly snore loudly.'

b. Marek *jistě* ne-chrápe nahlas.
Marek NEG-snores certainly/ uncertainly loudly
lit. 'Marek certainly doesn't snore loudly.'

As for the other projections proposed, Czech proves to show equivalent scope interactions as the original data. The only possible order of the elements corresponding to each phrase respectively, is the one that follows the structural order of these projections as originally proposed. As a result, the only possible order is the one demonstrated by (85-a) where *mimochodem* 'by the way' precedes the adverb *upřímně* 'honestly' in ComP and *určitě* 'surely' in JP. If we were to scramble these elements around, we get an ungrammatical structure, or, as in (85-b),

we get an interpretative shift where *určitě* 'surely' is taken to be an intensifier of the adverb *upřímně* 'honestly'. Additionally so, as noted even by Krifka (2020) for German, ActP modifiers can serve as parentheticals, i.e., they can be freely inserted anywhere in the clause, however, they need to be intonationally distinguished by a pause. Essentially the same applies for Czech.

(85) a. Marek *mimochodem upřímně určitě* chrápe dost nahlas.
Marek by.the.way honestly surely snores very loudly
'By the way, Marek honestly for sure snores very loudly.'
b. *Marek *mimochodem určitě upřímně* chrápe dost nahlas.
c. *Marek *upřímně mimochodem určitě* chrápe dost nahlas.
d. *Marek *upřímně určitě mimochodem* chrápe dost nahlas.

Additionally for assertions, when we turn back to examples from (58) and try to extend this proposal as a potential supporting diagnostic for the landing site of the verb in a position similar to questions, we arrive at examples like (86). In (86), we see that the verb along with the clitic are positioned very high, i.e. above epistemic adverbs *doopravdy* 'really' and *určitě* 'surely' which we established to sit in the left periphery in their respective projections. Given this observation, we might again argue that at least in terms of statement-question opposition, it suggests that movement itself might not be answer for the inability of NCI licensing.

(86) **Ne-**smál se *doopravdy určitě* **nikdy** tak nahlas.
NEG-laughed REFL really surely never.NCI this loud
'He truly for sure didn't ever laugh so loud.'

Next, we will take a look at how these individual projections play out beyond assertions. Since in Czech, the distinction between interrogative questions and declarative questions makes a significant difference as for the licensing of NCIs, we focus mainly on how Krifka (2021) manages to distinguish between these in his framework and how this proposal fits when extended to the Czech dataset.

3.4.2 Questions and Beyond

As for the internal structure of questions, Krifka (2021) assumes that all proposed projections are also present in questions no matter whether interrogative or declarative. Concretely, Krifka (2021) proposed that it is an operator that changes in the structure and ultimately yields a question reading, the interrogative operator '?' that resides in ActP, see (87) for a simple positive polar question 'Did Max arrive?'. Unlike for assertions, Krifka assumes that this operator takes only the finite verb to ActP.

(87) $[_{ActP}\ [_{Act'}\ [_{Act^{o}}$? did$_0$] $[_{ComP}\ [_{C'}\ [_{C^{o}}\ \vdash]\ [_{JP}\ [_{J'}\ [_{J^{o}}$ J-] $[_{TP}$ Max arrive t$_0$]]]]]]]

For negated questions, he argues that since negation expresses additional pragmatic meaning, it resides in ComP, see (88). Additionally, since the pragmatic meaning is associated with the pragmatic layer in the left periphery, it needs no additional machinery as other approaches to negated questions and bias, cf. Romero & Han (2004); Repp (2013); AnderBois (2019).

(88) $[_{ActP}\ [_{Act'}\ [_{Act^{o}}$ did$_i$?] $[_{ComP}$ n't $[_{ComP}\ [_{C'}\ [_{C^{o}}\ \vdash]\ [_{JP}\ [_{J'}\ [_{J^{o}}$ J-] $[_{TP}$ Max t$_i$ arrive]]]]]]]]

Declarative questions, i.e., questions which retain the structure of assertions yet are uttered with a rising question intonation, are said to be similar to assertions in terms of the ability to host operators that cannot be usually hosted by interrogative questions. See the difference between (89-a) and (89-b) which shows that epistemic adverbs like *certainly* or *probably* are preferred in declarative questions.

(89) a. #Did Max certainly/probably arrive already?
b. Max certainly/ probably arrived already?

For this reason, which also aligns with declarative questions being inherently biased toward the proposition that shares the polarity of the question uttered (Gunlogson, 2002), they express a commitment by the speaker and resemble assertions. In their syntax, they thus resemble an assertive structure, see (90).

(90) [ActP [Act′ [Act^{o} •] [ComP [C′ [C^{o} □] [JP [J′ [J^{o} J-] [TP Max arrived]]]]]]]

As for embedded polar question, Krifka (2021) assumes the following structure in (91), similar to the one presented for interrogative questions. However, what differs here is that the CP hosting the complementizer happens to be below the projections introduced in connection to the Left Periphery.

(91) [ActP [Act′ [Act^{o} ?] [ComP [Com′ [Com^{o} □] [CP whether [TP Max arrived]]]]]]

However, to motivate these structural representations in Czech, more should be be said with regard to epistemic adverbs, concretely *náhodou* 'by any chance' which we discussed in Section 3.3.1 in connection to non-veridical contexts.

In Czech polar questions, *náhodou* is a particle that appears mostly in interrogative questions which dispose of negation. This has been linked particularly

to bias which is carried by negation in questions in Czech (Šimík, in press). However, since *náhodou* remains an epistemic adverb/particle, it can also be associated with a specific position within the clausal spine, namely JP while allowing to scramble to a higher structural position, see (92-a). When it appears in the TP layer, it gains a meaning associated with its original meaning as an adverb, i.e., 'accidentally', see Example (92-b).[14]

(92) a. (*Náhodou*) **ne-**přijede *náhodou* Marek?
by.any.chance NEG-arrive by.any.chance Marek
'Will Marek arrive by any chance?'

b. **Ne-**přijede Marek *náhodou*?
NEG-arrive Marek accidentally
'Will Marek arrive by accident?'

Many observations arise when it comes to the presence of ComP, however. In the proposal made by Krifka (2021), he argues that ComP is always present within the structure and does so primarily based on the fact that he assumes questions to be monopolar. Thus, the speaker always commits to p denoted by the question but wants the confirmation of the interlocutor. Since we assume questions to denote a set of all possible answers, it is important to further investigate the properties of ComP and additionally, whether ComP even takes place within the structure.

In the previous Section, we have noted that ComP can host expressions which are associated with the speaker and his commitment to the truth of the proposition denoted by the sentence. However, such expressions cannot be hosted in interrogative questions no matter their polarity. This is supported by the inability of questions to host expressions such as *upřímně* 'honestly', see (93-a).

When it comes to other expressions said to be associated with this projection such as *doopravdy* 'really', they can only be interpreted to modify *Marek*, and thus not to operate on the whole proposition, see (93-b). Additionally so, they cannot be interpreted as expressing commitment by the speaker. In fact, it signals that the commitment is demanded of the interlocutor when giving the answer to the posed question.

(93) a. (**Ne-**)chrápe (**upřímně*) Marek?
NEG-snore honestly Marek
'Does Marek honestly snore?'

b. (**Ne-**)chrápe (?*opravdu*) Marek?
NEG-snore really Marek
lit. 'Is it really Marek who snores?'

[14]However, in many cases, it is possible when the epistemic adverb receives a more prominent stress and/or is distinguished by a pause.

For declarative questions, the picture is quite different. In declarative questions, it is still possible to get the interpretation of 'by any chance'. However, this interpretation while yielding a grammatical structure is not available when there is no NCI such as *nikdy* 'never' in (94). When NCIs take place in this type of question, the forced interpretation is to view *náhodou* as 'accidentally', i.e. the meaning associated with a position within TP. We argue that this mutual exclusion shows that declarative questions can serve a genuine question function which allows adverbs to be interpreted as epistemic, or they serve an assertive function however still dependent on the interlocutor in terms of inclusion to the common ground.

(94) a. Marek *náhodou* *(**ne-**)chrápe (*__nikdy__)?
Marek by.any.chance NEG-snores never.NCI
'Marek snores by any chance?'

b. Marek náhodou *(**ne-**)chrápe **nikdy**?
Marek accidentally NEG-snores never.NCI
'Marek never snores by accident?'

In terms of other expressions associated with the left periphery, similar observations can be seen as for interrogative questions. Commitment expressions such as *upřímně* 'honestly' which are speaker-oriented are equally as unacceptable and moreover, they can only be interpreted in terms of their TP adverbial meaning, e.g. (95-a) which can only be interpreted as that Marek was an honest snorer. Expressions such as *opravdu* 'really' can appear in this type of question and again, it invites the speaker to be truthful and e.g. quit hedging in the discourse.

(95) a. Marek (**upřímně*) (**ne-**)chrápe?
Marek honestly NEG-snores
'Marek does(n't) snore honestly?'

b. Marek *opravdu* (**ne-**)chrápe?
Marek really NEG-snores
'Marek really does(n't) snore?'

The same can be seen for embedded questions in terms of interpretation. However, one thing has to be noted with regards to *náhodou* in embedded questions which contain NCIs. In these constructions, unlike for matrix questions, *náhodou* can, however very marginally, appear alongside NCIs while retaining the left periphery meaning of 'by any chance'. We argue that this is due to the embedded nature of questions which do not function as direct speech acts themselves and instead, report the speech acts uttered. This makes them weaker and insensible to the interplay seen in direct utterances.

(96) a. Ptal se, jestli Marek *náhodou* *(**ne-**)chrápe (?**nikdy**)?
he.asked REFL whether Marek by.any.chance NEG-snores never.NCI
'He asked whether Marek snores by any chance?'

b. Ptal se, jestli Marek (*upřímně) (**ne-**)chrápe?
he.asked REFL whether Marek honestly NEG-snores
'He asked whether Marek honestly does(n't) snore?'

c. Ptal se, jestli Marek opravdu (**ne-**)chrápe?
he.asked REFL whether Marek really NEG-snores
'He asked whether Marek really does(n't) snore?'

Thus, it can be seen that interrogative questions differ from their declarative and embedded counterparts in many respects, starting from the licensing of epistemic adverbs and other expressions associated with the left periphery. Next, we will turn to some general observations which can be drawn from the data discussed in this Section and proceed to the analysis in which the proposal by Krifka (2024) will play a significant role.

3.5 Interim Summary

The purpose of the current Section was to introduce the data under discussion in its entirety and explore the possible answers to the initial question of why interrogative questions lack the ability to license NCIs; something that is seen both in declarative questions and embedded questions in Czech.

Necessarily, we started out with a question that targeted movement, concretely the movement of the finite verb to the initial position, i.e. T-to-C movement. However, as was shown on constructions which demonstrate similar movement, such a theoretical explanation seems to be implausible for Czech, at least to attribute this behavior solely to this type of movement.

For this reason, we have sought to explore questions in terms of their utterance type and meaning, and what these characteristics can tell us with regard to their internal structure. Specifically, we have looked at negation in questions as an expletive element (Greco, 2019) which bears additional pragmatic meaning (Sudo, 2013). Due to this behavior and observations for other languages (Tsiakmakis & Espinal, 2022; Tsiakmakis, 2025), we have decided to pursue the proposal made by Krifka (2020, 2021, 2024) and explore the left periphery as a potential answer to our problem.

So far, we have only touched briefly on the left periphery in Czech polar questions and how these data tie together with the theoretical premises introduced in Section 2 regarding NC as syntactic agreement. For this reason, we turn to the core theoretical part of this thesis and present the analysis of Czech polar

questions through the theoretical lense of the left periphery.

4 Analysis

Before engaging in the analysis itself, we briefly summarize some of the core observations that will further motivate the analysis as it will be presented. Specifically, in connection to the left periphery, we will need to take a second look at what constitutes the Op$_{\neg}$ and what movement took place in Examples like (58), repeated here as (97).

(97) a. **Ne-**díval se **nikomu** do očí.
NEG-looked REFL nobody.NCI to eyes
'He didn't look into anybody's eyes.'

b. ***Ne-**díval se **nikomu** do očí?
NEG-looked REFL nobody.NCI to eyes
int. 'Didn't he look into anybody's eyes?'

c. **Ne-**přečetl si ji **NIKDO**.
NEG-read REFL her nobody.NCI
'Nobody has read it.'

d. ***Ne-**přečetl si ji **nikdo**?
NEG-read REFL her nobody.NCI
int. 'Nobody has read it.'

At the very beginning of the discussion of these examples, we have shown that at least superficially, these constructions are no different from each other and thus are expected to behave the same. However, questions proved to violate the NCI licensing mechanism, see (97-b) and (97-d). Crucially, this failure is not tied to movement as such, but to the interrogative clause type, since, as we have shown at length, the very same verb-initial configurations remain grammatical in declaratives.

Following Zeijlstra (2022), we have argued that the Op$_{\neg}$ is an adjunct that can in principle move freely in the structure so as to be able to check the [uNeg] feature of all the elements in the structure. In assertions, this premise holds since all the [uNeg] bearing elements can be scrambled in the sentence freely while the NC reading is still yielded normally as would be expected. However, there are still restrictions as to the Op$_{\neg}$ itself, namely that it cannot easily cross phase boundaries, as exemplified by long-distance scrambling out of an embedded clause, and possibly even the examples of embedded predicates and the extraction of elements out of them, both shown in (98). Following the observations from embedded predicates, we assume that each low, veridical NM, that is, each NM that is the reflex of a propositional Op$_{\neg}$, gives rise to one Op$_{\neg}$ respectively, essentially allowing for the DN interpretation. As we will argue in Section 4.1, the high

expletive negation of interrogatives is precisely the negation that is not such a reflex, and therefore introduces no Op$_{\neg}$.

(98) a. Petr chtěl, aby Pavel **ne**-koupil **žádnou** knihu
Petr wanted COMPL Pavel NEG-bought no.NCI book.ACC
Monice.
Monika.DAT
'Petr wanted Pavel to not buy any book for Monika.'

b. ***Žádnou** knihu Petr chtěl, aby Pavel **ne**-koupil <**žádnou** knihu>
Monice.

c. Petr se rozhodl [$_{TP}$ **ne**-rozbít **žádný** hrnek].
Petr REFL decided NEG-to.break no.NCI mug
'Petr decided not to break any mug.'

d. *Petr se [**žádný** hrnek] rozhodl [$_{TP}$ **ne**-rozbít <žádný hrnek>].

Only certain conclusions can be drawn from the data in (98). Concretely, we see that the movement of the Op$_{\neg}$ is subject to locality restrictions which ultimately dissolve the NC relationship, or, as shown in Section 2.3.5, feed it. Thus, for assertions, we want to capture this exact interaction where NC takes place no matter the position of the negative elements bearing the [uNeg] feature.

In the remainder of the current Section, let us turn to a derivation of an assertive clause exemplified in (99). Following Kosta (2001), we assume that the TP layer with propositional content contains a NegP where the verb adjoins to the *ne-* prefix, a direct reflex of the Op$_{\neg}$ in the structure which resides in a given proposition as an adjunct but moves freely in the structure. The verbal head thus cyclically moves up in the structure through AspP, NegP and finally to TP, where its [uNeg] feature gets checked by the Op$_{\neg}$. Simultaneously, due to Multiple Agree, the [uNeg] borne by the NCI *nikoho* 'nobody' left in the complement position of VP is checked as well. Since both [uNeg] features are checked, an NC reading is established.

Crucially for assertions, since the NC reading has already been established within one clause as an agreement mechanism, neither the movement of the verb nor of the NCI breaks it, even when scrambled to the initial position associated with questions. In the derivation, we assume that in the left periphery of the structure, concretely in ActP, there is an assertion operator • which is responsible for the declarative configuration as well as the assertive interpretation of the utterance. For a schematic derivation of the current structure, see (100).

(99) Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho** z nich.
Marek NEG-saw nobody.NCI of them
'Marek didn't see any of them.'

(100) [$_{\text{ActP}}$ [$_{\text{Act'}}$ [$_{\text{Act}^\circ}$ •] [$_{\text{ComP}}$ [$_{\text{Com'}}$ [$_{\text{Com}^\circ}$ ⊢] [$_{\text{JP}}$ [$_{\text{J'}}$ [$_{\text{J}^\circ}$ J–] [$_{\text{TP}}$ Op$_{\neg\text{[iNeg]}}$ [$_{\text{TP}}$ Marek$_2$ [$_{\text{T'}}$ **ne-viděl**$_{\text{[uNeg]}1}$ [$_{\text{NegP}}$ [$_{\text{Neg'}}$ [$_{\text{Neg}^\circ}$ t$_1$] [$_{\text{AspP}}$ t$_1$ [$_{\text{vP}}$ t$_2$ [$_{\text{v'}}$ t$_1$ [$_{\text{VP}}$ t$_1$ [$_{\text{DP}}$ **nikoho**$_{\text{[uNeg]}}$ z nich]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]

Next, building off of the assertive configuration described above, we turn to interrogative polar questions.

4.1 Interrogative Polar Questions

For interrogative questions, we will further have to revise the agreement mechanism between the negated verb and any other [uNeg] bearing elements. As we have repeatedly pointed out, the lack of NC seems not to be connected to movement per se, only to its specific instances where it crosses a relevant boundary such as the CP or an embedded predicate boundary. Given these observations, it would be an objectionable conclusion to incorporate a movement-based explanation of the data for interrogative questions under the assumption that the Op$_\neg$ can move into positions that are associated with question movement.

For this reason, we would like to argue that a restriction must be put on the Merge of Op$_\neg$ instead. Concretely speaking, the Op$_\neg$ is merged only in the TP domain, although it can move freely within the structure as an adjunct. Furthermore, we assume that the NM can be a direct reflex of the presence of the Op$_\neg$ only in certain configurations, such as assertions.

This is intertwined with interrogative questions in the following way. As we have already seen for Modern Greek, which distinguishes between *min*, an expletive negative element, and *dhen*, a standard negation marker which participates in the NC reading, we essentially assume the same can be said for Czech. Thus, in Czech, we would expect that negation can have two Merge sites in the derivation. One which we have seen in assertions already and that has been said to lie in between TP and AspP, and one that lies in the left periphery, concretely a dedicated NegP below JP. However, the high left periphery merge site is not associated with standard negation which can participate in the NC reading and instead, it is an expletive element that gains a pragmatic interpretation, i.e., bias as exemplified in (71). The Op$_\neg$ cannot be merged together with the expletive high negation in the left periphery, since it can only be merged earlier in the derivation. This correlates with the non-negative interpretation of these questions.

We tie the availability of this high merge site to *clause-typing* (Cheng, 1991). Concretely, we argue that the interrogative operator '?' in ActP types the clause as non-veridical and thereby licenses negation in the high, expletive position. What forces the high position to be the only available one in matrix interrogatives is the fact that '?' must be satisfied by raising the finite verb to ActP. Since the finite verb raises to ActP, the only negation that can be spelled out on it is the negation

merged in its raising path, i.e. the high NegP below JP. A low NegP, and with it the $Op_{\neg}$, would be stranded below the raised verb and could not surface on it. For this reason, in matrix interrogatives, whenever negation appears, it is necessarily the high expletive negation, and any negative import can only be contributed lower by an embedded predicate, as we show below for Example (105).

The derivation of a question such as the one captured in (101) then proceeds as follows, see (102) and its schematic derivation in Figure 3. Just as already seen in assertions, the subject *Marek* moves and lands in the Spec,TP position. Simultaneously, due to the presence of the '?' operator which requires the finite verb to move to ActP, the verbal head moves cyclically up in the structure through the projections in the TP layer and, gaining its negative prefix in the high NegP, to the head of ActP. However, since the high negation is separate from the merging of the $Op_{\neg}$, an NC relationship can never be established. For this reason, the [uNeg] feature on the NCI *nikoho* 'nobody' can never be checked off and thus yields an ungrammatical structure, marked in the derivation by the star on the unchecked NCI.

(101) *__Ne__-viděl Marek **nikoho** z nich?
NEG-saw Marek nobody.NCI of them
int. 'Is it the case that Marek didn't see any of them?'

(102) $[_{ActP}$ $[_{Act'}$ $[_{Act^{\circ}}$ **ne**-viděl$_1$?] $[_{ComP}$ $[_{Com'}$ $[_{Com^{\circ}}$ ⊢] $[_{JP}$ $[_{J'}$ $[_{J^{\circ}}$ J–] $[_{NegP}$ $[_{Neg'}$ $[_{Neg^{\circ}}$ t_1] $[_{TP}$ Marek$_2$ $[_{T'}$ t_1 $[_{AspP}$ t_1 $[_{vP}$ t_2 $[_{v'}$ t_1 $[_{VP}$ t_1 $[_{DP}$ ***nikoho**$_{[uNeg]}$ z nich]]]]]]]]]]]]]]

Essentially, this is the reason why the same configuration but with a PPI is rendered grammatical, see (103). Since the verbal head gets its prefix *ne-* in a higher projection that sits above the possible merge site of the $Op_{\neg}$, and thus the $Op_{\neg}$ never takes place, the presence of a PPI is permitted.

(103) **Ne**-viděl Marek někoho z nich?
NEG-saw Marek someone.PPI of them
'Didn't Marek see some of them?'

This availability is further suggested by the scopal interpretation of negated interrogative questions. If we expected the negation to be merged low, it should also be possible to retrieve the original scopal position and thus get the interpretation of (104-a), which corresponds to a question asking about an individual that was not seen by Marek. Instead, what we get is the interpretation of (104-b).

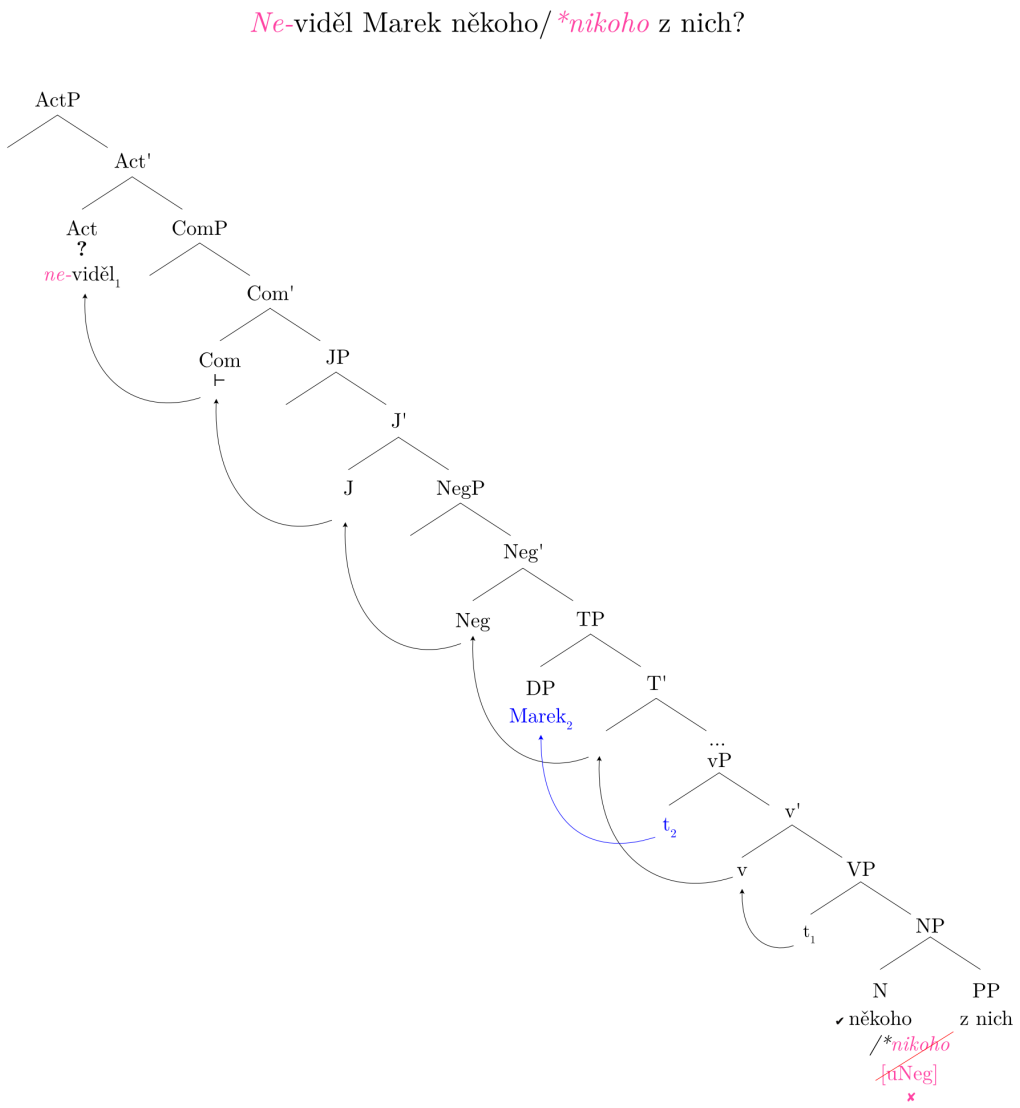

Figure 3: Schematic tree diagram for interrogative polar questions in Czech.

(104) **Ne**viděl Marek někoho (z nich)?

a. ≠ Is there someone whom Marek didn't see?

b. = Is there someone whom Marek saw?

Since the high negation is optional, its presence adds the biased, evaluative interpretation discussed in Section 3.3.3, while its absence yields a neutral positive question. In neither case is the $Op_{\neg}$ available, which is why positive interrogatives equally fail to license NCIs. This optionality is expected under the current proposal, since the high NegP is merged as an expletive, pragmatically loaded element rather than as the reflex of a propositional $Op_{\neg}$.

The prediction of the two merge sites is confirmed by biclausal structures in which both are realized at once, see Example (105). In such configurations,

negation on the matrix modal *mít* 'should' is the high expletive negation forced by verb-raising to ActP, and as expected it does not license an NCI. However, negation on the embedded infinitive *jít* 'go' is a low, veridical negation which is the reflex of an embedded $\text{Op}_\neg$ and therefore licenses the NCI *nikam* 'nowhere' locally, see the derivation in (106).

(105) a. **Ne**-měl táta jít do práce/ (***nikam**)?
NEG-should dad to.go to work/ nowhere.NCI
'Shouldn't dad go to work/ nowhere?'

b. **Ne**-měl táta **ne**-jít do práce/ **nikam**?
NEG-should dad NEG-to.go to work/ nowhere.NCI
'Shouldn't dad not go to work/ nowhere?'

(106) $[_{\text{ActP}}\ [_{\text{Act'}}\ [_{\text{Act}^\circ}\ \textbf{ne-}\text{měl}_1\ ?]\ \ [_{\text{ComP}}\ [_{\text{Com'}}\ [_{\text{Com}^\circ}\ \vdash]\ [_{\text{JP}}\ [_{\text{J'}}\ [_{\text{J}^\circ}\ \text{J}-]\ [_{\text{NegP}}\ [_{\text{Neg'}}\ [_{\text{Neg}^\circ}\ \text{t}_1]\ [_{\text{TP}}\ \text{táta}_2\ [_{\text{T'}}\ \text{t}_1\ [_{\text{AspP}}\ \text{t}_1\ [_{\text{vP}}\ \text{t}_2\ [_{\text{v'}}\ \text{t}_1\ [_{\text{VP}}\ \text{t}_1\ [_{\text{TP}}\ \text{Op}_{\neg[\text{iNeg}]}\ [_{\text{TP}}\ \text{PRO}\ [_{\text{T'}}\ \textbf{ne-jít}_{[\text{uNeg}]3}\ [_{\text{NegP}}\ [_{\text{Neg'}}\ [_{\text{Neg}^\circ}\ \text{t}_3]\ [_{\text{VP}}\ \text{t}_3\ \textbf{nikam}_{[\text{uNeg}]}]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]$

Crucially, when two veridical NMs are present, as in an assertion with the same two verbs, we would obtain a double negation reading. This follows because each NM that is the reflex of a propositional $\text{Op}_\neg$ contributes a semantic negation, so two such markers cancel out. The unavailability of this double negation reading in interrogative questions confirms that the matrix high negation cannot be a reflex of an $Op_\neg$. To fully understand the picture, let us now turn to declarative questions and their structure.

4.2 Declarative Polar Questions

Turning to declarative polar questions, we see that they crucially retain an assertion type of structure, but are viewed as questions in a communicative discourse. Based on those assumptions, we already pointed out that they lack the '?' operator seen in interrogative questions and instead, the assertion operator • is merged in the head of ActP. For this reason, declarative questions do not display movement of the verb to the initial position and instead, the verb stays in the TP layer and allows NC to take place.

In the derivation, we will be concerned with Example (107), where an NCI is licensed, see also Figure 4 for a tree diagram. Structurally, the question resembles an assertion. Given the • operator, no movement of the verb to the initial position takes place and thus, the verb only moves in the structure to the head of TP. Given the lack of the '?' operator, NegP is also merged low, so when the verb cyclically moves through it, the [uNeg] feature gained there can be checked off by the $\text{Op}_\neg$ together with the NCI, here *nikoho* 'nobody', see (108).

(107) Marek **ne**-viděl **nikoho** z nich?
Marek NEG-saw nobody.NCI of them
'Marek didn't see any of them?'

(108) [$_{ActP}$ [$_{Act'}$ [$_{Act^\circ}$ •] [$_{ComP}$ [$_{Com'}$ [$_{Com^\circ}$ ⊢] [$_{JP}$ [$_{J'}$ [$_{J^\circ}$ J–] [$_{TP}$ Op$_{\neg[iNeg]}$ [$_{TP}$ Marek$_2$ [$_{T'}$ **ne**-viděl$_{[uNeg]1}$ [$_{NegP}$ [$_{Neg'}$ [$_{Neg^\circ}$ t$_1$] [$_{AspP}$ t$_1$ [$_{vP}$ t$_2$ [$_{v'}$ t$_1$ [$_{VP}$ t$_1$ [$_{DP}$ **nikoho**$_{[uNeg]}$ z nich]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]

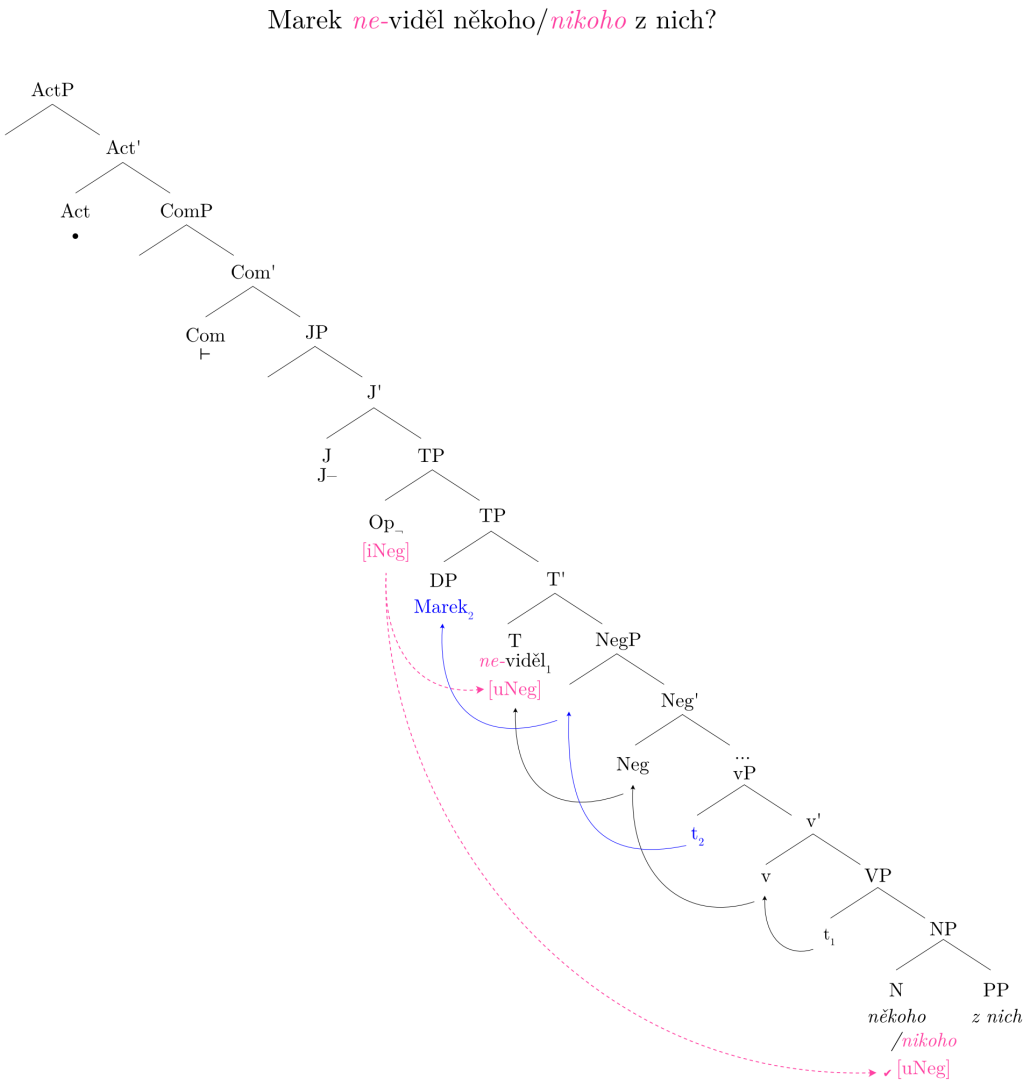

Figure 4: Schematic tree diagram for declarative polar questions in Czech.

The ability of NegP to be merged lower in declarative questions is further supported by the near-veridical nature of declarative questions. As Krifka proposes, declarative questions can be viewed as monopolar, i.e., denoting a single proposition and not a set, which was previously claimed for interrogative

questions. Thus, not only is NegP merged low and thereby serving as standard negation, but the structure is also unable to host, or hosts only with significant degradation, epistemic adverbs that are associated with non-veridical contexts, such as *náhodou* 'by any chance', see (109). Since *náhodou* resides in JP and requires the non-veridical, '?'-typed configuration, it cannot receive its epistemic reading here, where negation is low and the clause is assertion-like. The NCI and *náhodou* are thereby in complementary distribution, since they diagnose the two different negation sites.

(109) */??Marek *náhodou* **ne-**viděl **nikoho** z nich?
Marek by.any.chance NEG-saw nobody.NCI of them
int. 'Is it the case, by any chance, that Marek didn't see any of them?'

Last but not least, in the next part, we will see how this plays out in embedded questions.

4.3 Embedded Polar Questions

In embedded questions, as already discussed for the left periphery, we assume that the operator present in the derivation is the '?' operator seen in questions. Because a question itself remains a question but takes the form of a reported speech act, it ultimately also brings forward differences in terms of the availability of NC. Crucially, we see that in the derivation, what satisfies '?' in ActP instead of the verb is *jestli* ('whether'), i.e. the clause-typing of the embedded question is done via the complementizer itself, base-generated in ActP. Since the complementizer satisfies '?', the finite verb is not forced to raise and can be merged in a position that corresponds to low negation. The high NegP, although licensed by the '?'-typed clause, is not forced, so the low $Op_{\neg}$ is available and the NCI is licensed, see (111) and a schematic tree diagram in Figure 5.

(110) Ptal se, jestli Marek **ne-**viděl **nikoho** z nich.
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek NEG-saw nobody.NCI of them
'He asked whether whether Marek saw nobody.'

(111) [$_{ActP}$ [$_{Act'}$ [$_{Act°}$ jestli ?] [$_{ComP}$ [$_{Com'}$ [$_{Com°}$ ⊢] [$_{JP}$ [$_{J'}$ [$_{J°}$ J–] [$_{TP}$ $Op_{\neg[iNeg]}$ [$_{TP}$ Marek$_2$ [$_{T'}$ **ne-**viděl$_{[uNeg]1}$ [$_{NegP}$ [$_{Neg'}$ [$_{Neg°}$ t$_1$] [$_{AspP}$ t$_1$ [$_{vP}$ t$_2$ [$_{v'}$ t$_1$ [$_{VP}$ t$_1$ [$_{DP}$ **nikoho**$_{[uNeg]}$ z nich]]]]]]]]]]]]]]]

Additionally, as we have already discussed, it is marginally possible for speakers to have the epistemic adverb *náhodou* 'by any chance' along with an NCI, see (112), something we previously established as causing friction in declarative questions. This fact follows from the structure just proposed. Since em-

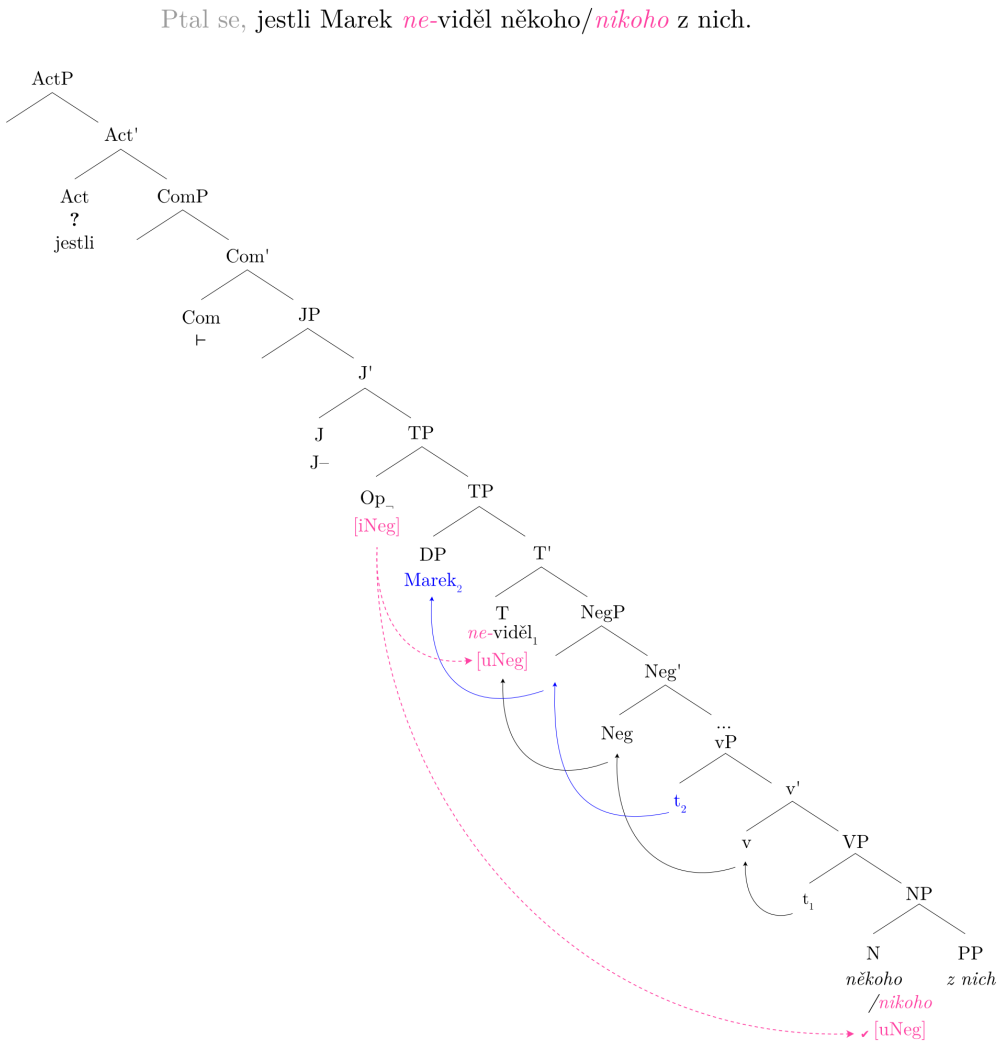

Figure 5: Schematic tree diagram for embedded polar questions in Czech.

bedded questions contain the '?' operator, they are inherently non-veridical and thus license epistemic adverbs in JP. At the same time, since the head of ActP is already occupied by the clause-typing complementizer *jestli*, the verb remains low in the TP layer, so a low negation and its Op¬ are available, and the NCI is licensed. Embedded questions are thus the only configuration in which both a JP-licensed epistemic adverb and a low, NCI-licensing negation can marginally coexist, precisely because the clause is '?'-typed yet the verb stays low.

(112) ?Ptal se, jestli Marek *náhodou* **ne**-viděl **nikoho** z
he.asked REFL COMPL Marek by.any.chance NEG-saw nobody.NCI of
nich.
them
'He asked whether it was the case that Marek didn't see any of them by

any chance'

The analysis presented here further relates to the fear-clauses previously discussed for non-veridical contexts. As already seen, fear-clauses constitute an example where negation is not interpreted as negative, the same expletive nature as we have argued for negation in interrogative questions, see (113). For questions, however, negation is optional, and this optionality brings about pragmatic effects not seen in fear-clauses. This is expected under the assumption that the two utterance types differ in their denotation: questions denote a set of possible answers, whereas fear-clauses do not. We take the parallel to be that in both, the negation is the high, expletive one which does not give rise to an $Op_{\neg}$ and therefore cannot license an NCI.

(113) Bojí se, aby *náhodou* *(**ne-**)přišel Marek.
he.fears REFL COMPL by.any.chance NEG-came Marek
'He fears that Marek might come by any chance.'

We note, however, that the precise syntactic configuration responsible for the failure of NC in fear-clauses remains an open question. Unlike interrogative and embedded questions, fear-clauses are typed by the subjunctive complementizer *aby* (Biskup, 2020; Čakányová, 2025) rather than by the '?' operator, and a full account of how the high expletive negation is licensed in this configuration, and of the role of the subjunctive complementizer in blocking a low $Op_{\neg}$, is beyond the scope of the current thesis. We therefore leave the derivation of fear-clauses as a matter for future research, while maintaining that the descriptive parallel with interrogative questions, expletive high negation, non-veridicality, and the failure to license NCIs, is notable.

Thus, we have seen that the data suggest, in line with the reasoning of Dimitrova (2022); Zanon (2025); Penka (2020), that the reason behind the inability of NCIs in interrogative questions has to do with negation and the two merge sites available per clause. Crucially for the analysis, when a clause is typed as a non-veridical utterance and the finite verb must raise to satisfy the '?' operator, the merge site of negation is positioned in the left periphery, which does not give rise to the $Op_{\neg}$ and thus disables the NC relationship. In the next Section, we conclude the current thesis and engage with some open questions which could not be answered here.

5 Conclusion

The aim of this thesis was to introduce crucial data showing that negative concord can apparently break down in interrogative clauses in Czech, a phenomenon not

found in other types of questions, nor in assertive clauses that are superficially reminiscent of their interrogative counterparts. Following Zeijlstra (2004, 2022), we have established that negative concord should be viewed through the lenses of syntactic agreement between a covert negative operator bearing an [iNeg] feature and other negative elements that bear a [uNeg] feature that is checked off by the operator during the derivation. For Czech specifically, it was assumed that the negative operator is always present in the derivation when expressing a negative meaning, with the negative marker on the verb as a reflex of its presence.

Crucially, we have also discussed that for Czech, the relationship between the negative operator and NCIs should be viewed as syntactic, especially when compared to other NPIs as was shown in Section 2.3. While NPIs are sensitive to for example, downward-entailment and likelihood which NCIs are inert to, NCIs were shown to be sensitive to locality constraints. Concretely, NCIs seem to bleed or feed the NC relationship only based on the locality with the negative operator such as in neg-raising constructions or long-distance scrambling. Given these observations, we concluded that the reason for the unavailability must be reflected in the syntax of interrogatives to be able to account for the broken NC relationship even when both NM and NCIs are in the same local domain.

However, in Section 3 when asking the question whether T-to-C movement is responsible for the unavailability, we arrived at the conclusion that this cannot be the answer. Since Czech disposes of structures which are superficially equivalent to interrogative word order, yet the NC relationship holds normally, we abandoned the idea that solely movement is responsible. Instead, we decided to engage with questions as an utterance type, what constitutes them and what this means for negation and its interpretation broadly, i.e. that negation in interrogative questions seems to resemble an expletive element. Comparing to other languages such as Modern Greek (Tsiakmakis, 2025), we decided to pursue the idea of the Left Periphery (Krifka, 2020, 2024) as the deciding factor for the expletive nature of negation and the inability to license NCIs.

For these reasons, we have thus proposed two possible merge sites of negation based on the clause typing of the utterance under discussion (Cheng, 1991). Interrogative questions are inherently non-veridical and non-negative in nature, and this non-veridical typing, expressed by the '?' operator in ActP, licenses negation in the high Left Periphery. What forces this high site to be the only available one in matrix interrogatives is that the '?' operator must be satisfied by raising the finite verb to ActP, so that the only negation which can be spelled out on the raised verb is the high, expletive one. In declarative and embedded polar questions, by contrast, the high site is not forced: declarative questions carry the assertion operator rather than '?', and embedded questions have their '?' satisfied

by the complementizer *jestli*, so in both the verb remains low, the low negation is available as a reflex of the negative operator, and NC obtains. The same reasoning extends to the biclausal case, where a high expletive negation on the matrix modal and a low veridical negation on the embedded infinitive co-occur in a single sentence, each with its own import. This further required a reconsideration of the nature of the negative operator. Concretely, that the negation marker on the verb can only be a reflex of the negative operator when negation is merged low. Furthermore, the negative operator can take place only in the propositional layer at TP; and since it can check the [uNeg] before scrambling takes place, the NC relationship holds.

Some issues arise with the current analysis as proposed here which are worth mentioning as open for future research. First, the precise syntactic configuration of fear-clauses remains unresolved. Fear-clauses display the same expletive high negation and the same failure to license NCIs as interrogative questions, yet they are typed not by the '?' operator but by the subjunctive complementizer *aby*. A promising lead is offered by Baunaz & Demonie (2025), who observe that languages of the Czech type express negative fear-clauses by shifting the mood of the embedded clause toward epistemic certainty, in Slavic via the complementizer; this suggests that *aby* may perform a clause-typing role analogous to '?', but a full derivation is left for future research. Second, we have not provided a compositional formalization of the interaction between the non-veridicality of the question operator and the antiveridicality of standard negation. While we have argued that the high negation contributes no antiveridical import and that the resulting bias is a pragmatic inference, a formal account of how these operators compose to yield precisely this effect without negative import remains to be worked out. Third, the analysis rests on a morphology-semantics dissociation of the negative marker, since a single exponent *ne-* spells out two Merge positions with distinct semantic imports. We take the across-the-board syncretism described by Baunaz & Demonie (2025), where standard, modal, and expletive negation are realized alike and situated within a single negative functional sequence, as convergent support for treating the high and low *ne-* as two spellouts of one sequence rather than two lexically distinct negations.

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